MSC MARRIAGE AND FAMILY THERAPY

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MFT 701

Fundamentals of Marriage and Family Therapy

14 teaching weeks · 23 practicals · 15 worked cases · 6 figures

SEMESTER ONE

1.71 units · Prerequisite: none

> “This is the course that turns a helping professional into a systemic one.”

One of 28 self-contained course books in the MSc Marriage and Family Therapy lecture library: a full taught semester per volume, with cases, practicals, assessment briefs, glossaries and model answers.

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MFT 701 — Fundamentals of Marriage and Family Therapy

MSc Marriage and Family Therapy · Semester One · 1.71 Units · 14 teaching weeks · Prerequisite: none

This volume is one of 28 course books that together cover the whole MSc Marriage and Family Therapy taught programme. Each book is written to carry a 14–16 week semester on its own: every week pairs a core idea with the practice that follows from it, a worked case, and a reflective task, and each book closes with an integration chapter, a glossary and a self-assessment paper with model answers.

The books are designed to be read straight through before the semester begins, revisited week by week, and used again in revision. Cross-references point to the other volumes where a topic is treated in more depth.

How to cite this volume

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A note on the case material

All families, couples and individuals in this book are fictional composites. They are written to teach pattern recognition, not to describe any real person. Nothing here replaces supervised clinical practice, professional registration, legal advice or medical care; legal content is orientation only and must be checked against the law of the relevant jurisdiction.

The lecture library

Twenty-eight self-contained course books carry the taught programme: eight in Semester One, seven in Semester Two, seven in Semester Three including the thesis, and six electives. The volume you are holding is marked in the margin.

Code	Course	Semester	Units
MFT 701	**Fundamentals of Marriage and Family Therapy**	One	1.71

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Course leader's summary. This is the course that turns a helping professional into a systemic one. It covers the intellectual history of family therapy, the epistemology that separates it from individual work, the profession's identity and scope, and the basic architecture of a first session. Everything later in the programme — theory, technique, assessment, ethics — assumes the vocabulary built here.

How to use this book

Each week contains four things: **the idea** (what you must understand), **the practice** (what you must be able to do), **the case** (what it looks like in a room), and **a reflective task** (what it asks of you personally). Read the week before the lecture; do the practical in the lab; write the reflection within 48 hours, while it is still uncomfortable.

The book is written to be read straight through, but it is also designed for revision: the integration chapter at the end compresses the whole course into two pages, and the glossary defines every term the examination may use.

1. Course description and rationale

Most mental health training teaches us to look inside a person: their thoughts, their symptoms, their attachment history. Family therapy teaches us to look between people: the loop, the triangle, the rule that nobody wrote down. This is not a rejection of individual psychology. It is an additional discipline of attention, and it changes what counts as the problem, the cause, and the cure.

Consider three common presentations:

Presentation	Individual formulation	Systemic formulation
A 15-year-old refuses school	Anxiety disorder, school phobia	A child whose symptoms hold a parental conflict at bay; the school refusal is the family's most effective way of preventing an argument about the marriage
A wife is "depressed"	Major depressive episode	A woman in a triad with her husband and his mother, carrying the family's unspoken grief about a lost pregnancy
A man "works too much"	Workaholism, avoidance	The person who regulates the family's emotional temperature by being absent, in a system that rewards his absence

None of these systemic formulations is automatically more true. Each is a hypothesis with different implications for where you intervene. The mature clinician holds both — the individual and the relational — and chooses deliberately.

Why this course first. Because students who begin with technique learn to do something they cannot explain, and students who begin with theory learn to explain something they cannot do. MFT 701 begins with framing: what kind of problem is this, and therefore what kind of help is required?

2. Learning outcomes

By the end of the course, students will be able to:

#	Outcome	Assessed in
LO1	Explain the epistemological shift from linear to circular causality, and its clinical consequences	Exam, Week 2 log
LO2	Trace the historical development of family therapy and locate contemporary models within it	Exam
LO3	Describe the profession's identity, scope of practice, and relationship to allied professions	Assignment
LO4	Conduct a structured first session, including joining, problem definition, and contracting	Skills assessment
LO5	Draw a three-generation genogram and generate hypotheses from it	Assignment
LO6	Critically discuss the common-factors evidence and its implications for model choice	Exam essay
LO7	Identify their own family-of-origin patterns and describe their effect on clinical work	Reflective log

3. Assessment

Component	Weight	Due
Reflective practice log (weekly, 300–400 words)	20%	Fortnightly
Genogram and hypothesis assignment (2,000 words + diagram)	30%	Week 9
Two-hour written examination (seen case + essay + short answers)	50%	Week 15

Skills gate. Students must pass a 15-minute observed first session (Week 6) before proceeding to MFT 706. The gate is pass/fail with one resit.

4. The fourteen-week teaching plan

Week	Topic	Practical	Core reading
1	What is family therapy? The relational turn	Triad: "the problem as described"	Nichols ch. 1; Handbook ch. 1
2	Linear and circular causality; first- and second-order cybernetics	Observation of a recorded argument	Watzlawick, Pragmatics ch. 1
3	A short history: from schizophrenia research to evidence-based practice	Timeline construction	Nichols ch. 2–3
4	Systems thinking: boundaries, feedback, homeostasis, rules	Feedback-loop mapping exercise	Becvar & Becvar ch. 2

Week	Topic	Practical	Core reading
5	The profession: identity, scope, settings, teamwork	Role boundaries case discussion	AAMFT code, scope sections
6	The first session I: joining, and the referral question	**Observed skills gate**	Minuchin & Fishman ch. 1
7	The first session II: defining the problem in the family's language	Triad: problem definition	Haley, Leaving Home ch. 1
8	The genogram as a hypothesis machine	Genogram lab (own family)	McGoldrick, Genograms ch. 1–2
9	Formulating relationally: the 5-P grid applied to a family	Formulation workshop	Dallos & Draper ch. 4
10	Culture, class and power in the consulting room	Reflexivity exercise	McGoldrick, Ethnicity & Family Therapy
11	Evidence: what works, for whom, and the common factors	Appraisal of one RCT and one qualitative study	Wampold ch. 2
12	Ethics, risk and the limits of the systemic frame	Risk-screen rehearsal	MFT 704 pre-reading
13	Integration I: three models applied to one family	Live demonstration + discussion	Nichols ch. 10
14	Integration II: your emerging clinical stance	Position statement presentation	Course review

Week 1 — What is family therapy? The relational turn

1.1 The lecture in ninety minutes

Week 1 has one job: to make the relational frame feel inevitable rather than eccentric. Everything a student does later — the first session, the genogram, the formulation, the ethics of conjoint work — assumes they can see a relationship as a thing with a shape, a history and a set of rules. Students arrive able to see people. Very few arrive able to see between people.

The ninety minutes run like this.

Minutes	Segment	What the lecturer does	What students do
0–10	Two formulations	Read the Okonkwo referral twice: once as an individual case, once as a relational one	Note which version they would have written
10–30	Where the field came from	The three failures of the individual frame (1.2)	Timeline exercise: place five founding texts
30–50	Five claims of the relational frame	Build the list on the board, testing each against a live example	Vote: which claim is hardest to accept?
50–65	Systems as a way of thinking	Cybernetics, feedback, the Watzlawick axioms (1.5)	Map one family loop on paper

Minutes	Segment	What the lecturer does	What students do
65–80	Three openings in a first session	Annotated transcript, read aloud in parts	Mark where the therapist widened the field
80–90	Set the lab and the journal	Hand out the widening-question protocol (1.11)	Form triads, choose a real (non-clinical) difficulty

The lecture is deliberately front-loaded with history. Students who know the field's origins stop treating systemic thinking as a technique among techniques and start treating it as an epistemology — a claim about what kind of thing a problem is.

1.2 Why the field exists: three failures of the individual frame

Family therapy was not invented because someone preferred groups to individuals. It was invented because three well-funded, well-intentioned research programmes ran into the same wall: the individual frame kept losing information that mattered clinically.

The first failure: the patient kept relapsing into a family. In the 1950s, Gregory Bateson's research group at Palo Alto — Bateson, Don Jackson, Jay Haley and John Weakland — was studying communication in families where one member had been diagnosed with schizophrenia. Their 1956 paper, "Toward a theory of schizophrenia," proposed the **double bind**: a pattern in which a person receives two messages at different logical levels that contradict each other, cannot comment on the contradiction, and cannot leave the field. A mother who says "come here, dear" while stiffening when the child approaches; a father who asks for honesty and then punishes it; a family that requires affection and forbids the expression of need that would make affection possible.

The double-bind theory has not survived as an explanation of schizophrenia. Its status as a causal claim about psychosis is dead, and students should know that. But something else in that research survived and became the spine of the field: the observation that **sequences of behaviour between people carry information that is invisible when you describe the people separately.** The patient's behaviour was intelligible as a move in a game; the game was not in the patient.

The second failure: the symptom made sense at home. Independently, researchers studying families of people with serious mental illness — Theodore Lidz at Yale, Lyman Wynne at the National Institute of Mental Health — noticed that families organised themselves around the symptomatic member. Wynne described **pseudo-mutuality**: a family that maintains the appearance of harmony by prohibiting any relationship that would threaten it. Lidz described **marital schism** and **marital skew**: two patterns in which the couple's conflict or the couple's imbalance shaped the child's development. Again the aetiological claims are dated. Again the structural insight held: **a family can be organised by a symptom**, and the symptom can be doing work for the system.

The third failure: the child was the family's messenger. The child guidance movement of the 1920s–1950s treated the child, advised the mother, and sent both home to a household that had not changed. Clinicians began to notice that improvement in the child was routinely followed by a new symptom in a sibling, or in the mother, or by a marital crisis that had been dormant. The pattern is now so familiar that it has a name —

symptom substitution — and the observation that produced it is the most practically useful idea in this week: if the symptom is functional for the system, removing the symptom without changing the system is unstable.

Three research programmes, three different populations, one conclusion: the unit of assessment was wrong. Between 1950 and 1975 the field built an alternative. Nathan Ackerman founded the Family Institute in 1960 and, with Jackson, the journal Family Process in 1962. Murray Bowen developed his theory of differentiation and multigenerational transmission at the Menninger Clinic and later at Georgetown. Virginia Satir was teaching conjoint family interviewing in California. Salvador Minuchin, working with delinquent boys at the Wiltwyck School and then at the Philadelphia Child Guidance Clinic, built structural family therapy out of the observation that these families were not sick so much as **organised at the wrong level of hierarchy** — children in charge, parents disengaged or in coalition, boundaries too diffuse or too rigid. Jay Haley joined Minuchin in Philadelphia in 1967 and brought strategy, power and the deliberate use of directives.

By the late 1970s the field had a canon: the Palo Alto communication school, Bowen's multigenerational theory, Minuchin's structural therapy, Haley and Madanes's strategic therapy, the Milan group's systemic therapy with its rituals and positive connotation, Satir's human validation, and the beginnings of solution-focused work at Milwaukee and narrative therapy in Adelaide and Auckland. Students will meet each of these properly in MFT 702. For now, one thing matters: **every one of these schools is an answer to the question "what is the unit?"** and each answers it slightly differently — the sequence, the generations, the structure, the meaning, the solution, the story.

> **DEBATE**
> "If the aetiological claims of the 1950s were wrong, the field built on them is unsound." Ten minutes, two sides. The strongest argument against: a science is allowed to keep its methods after discarding its first theories — medicine kept auscultation after humoral theory fell. The strongest argument for: the field has never fully shed the habit of blaming families for individual distress.

1.3 What "relational" actually means: five claims

"Systemic" is a word students learn to say before they learn to mean. Here are the five claims that make the relational frame a frame, in ascending order of how much they cost you as a clinician.

Claim 1 — Behaviour is patterned. Any two people who spend time together generate repeating sequences. The pattern is not in either person; it is in the loop. A couple who report "we never talk" will, within twenty minutes of a first session, demonstrate precisely how the not-talking is produced: one asks a question that contains an accusation, the other answers with a fact, the first escalates the volume, the second goes quiet. Neither is doing it to the other. Both are in it.

Claim 2 — The pattern is maintained by its consequences, not by its causes. This is cybernetics in one sentence. The question "why did this start?" is usually unanswerable and clinically useless; the question "what keeps it going?" is answerable and clinically decisive. A father's withdrawal is maintained by his wife's criticism, which is maintained by his withdrawal. Ten years of history explain how they got into the loop; only the loop explains why they are still in it.

Claim 3 — Meaning is negotiated between people. The same act means different things to different family members, and those meanings are not private. A daughter's silence means "respect" to her father, "punishment" to her mother, and "safety" to herself. The clinical task is not to find the true meaning but to make the several meanings audible to everyone in the room.

Claim 4 — Symptoms can serve the system. Not always, not deliberately, and never in a way that makes the symptomatic person responsible. But frequently enough that the therapist must ask: what would change in this household if this symptom disappeared tomorrow? Sometimes the honest answer is "nothing." Sometimes it is "my marriage would have to be looked at," and that answer reorganises the whole treatment.

Claim 5 — The observer is inside the observed system. You are not a camera. Your presence changes what the family does, what they say, what they notice about themselves, and what they will risk in front of each other. The family that arrives furious will perform its fury for you; the family that arrives polite will perform its politeness. This is not contamination to be minimised — it is the instrument you have. Second- order cybernetics, which students meet formally in MFT 715, is simply the discipline of using that instrument knowingly (Figure 1.1).

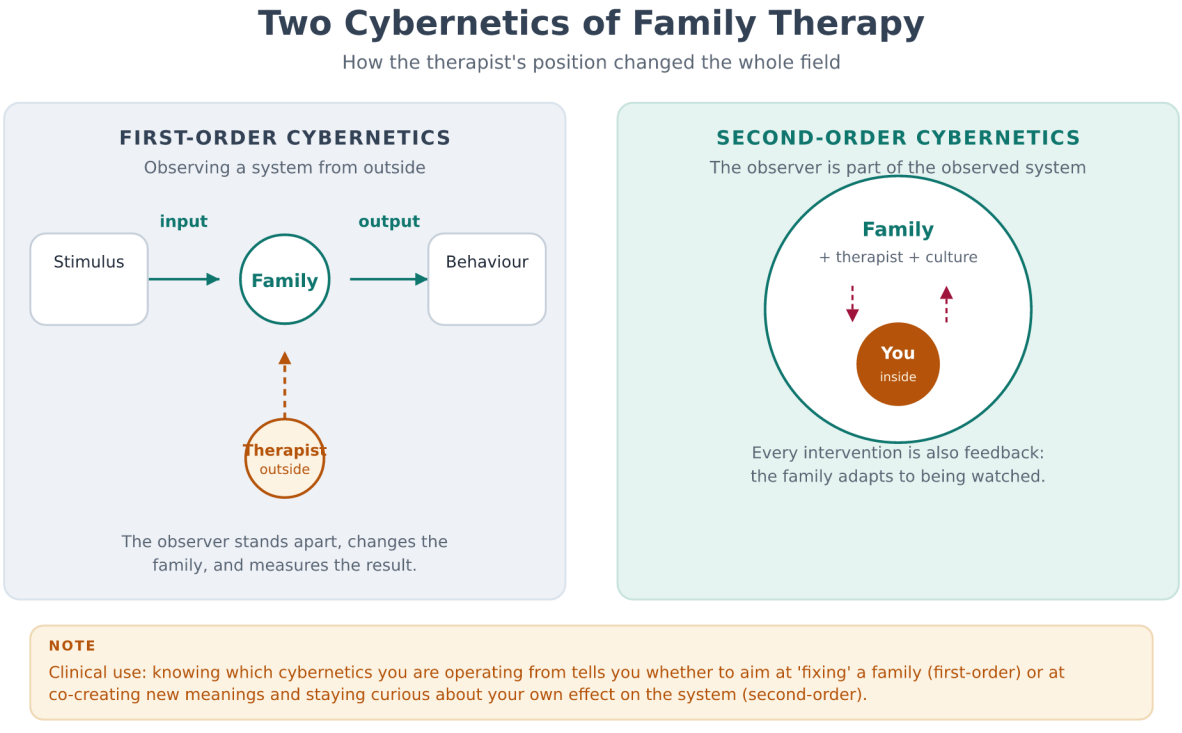


Figure 1.1 — First- and second-order cybernetics: where the therapist stands

A working definition. Marriage and family therapy is the assessment and treatment of relational systems — couples, families, and the wider networks in which they live — using interventions that target interaction patterns, meaning systems, and the emotional bonds between people. Read the definition carefully: assessment of relational systems means the unit of assessment is the relationship; interventions that target patterns means the unit of intervention is the loop, the rule, the structure or the story; emotional bonds means that a purely behavioural account is insufficient, because people are attached to each other and the attachment is what makes the pattern stubborn.

What it is not. Four clarifications, because students routinely collect the wrong ones.

1. **It is not "seeing everyone together" as a matter of policy.** Sometimes the right systemic move is an individual session inside family work. Conjoint work is a means, not a doctrine.
2. **It is not a denial that individuals exist, or that biology, trauma and temperament matter.** It is a disciplined focus on context, not a metaphysics.
3. **It is not the claim that families cause mental illness.** That claim was made in the 1950s and it was wrong, cruel, and expensive. Contemporary systemic practice holds families as the site where distress is expressed, maintained and relieved — not as the sole cause.
4. **It is not "we don't do diagnosis."** Systemic therapists diagnose, formulate and often work inside services that require a diagnosis; see MFT 707.

1.4 The four consequences, worked through

The four consequences in the original week note are worth more than a bullet list. Take them one at a time, each with what it changes on Monday morning.

Consequence 1 — The unit of assessment changes. You must hear from more than one person, and notice what happens between them. In practice this means the assessment cannot be completed in a single interview with one informant. It means disagreement between informants is data rather than noise: if the mother says the boy is defiant and the father says he is fine, the difference is the finding. It means you watch the room — who sits where, who answers for whom, who looks at whom before speaking, what happens to the volume when one person enters.

Consequence 2 — The unit of intervention changes. You intervene in sequences, rules, meanings and structures, not only in individual cognition. A cognitive intervention asks the depressed woman to examine the evidence for her belief that she is a burden. A systemic intervention asks what happens in the household in the forty-eight hours after she expresses that belief — and often finds that the expression triggers reassurance, that reassurance prevents any change in the division of labour, and that the division of labour is what is depressing her. Both are legitimate. The second is invisible from inside the first.

Consequence 3 — The definition of success changes. Success may be a family that argues well, not a family that never argues. This is the hardest consequence for students trained in symptom reduction, because it means the goal is not the absence of conflict but the presence of **repair**. A couple who can fight, rupture and come back together within an

hour is doing better than a couple who never fight and are quietly contemptuous. Outcome measures should reflect this: not only "has the symptom gone?" but "can this system handle disagreement without breaking?"

Consequence 4 — The therapist's position changes. You are not a technician outside the system; you are a participant who affects it. Three practical implications. First, you must account for your own effect: the family will behave differently because you are watching, and the difference is informative rather than annoying. Second, you cannot claim neutrality; you can only be transparent about your partiality. Third, your own family of origin is in the room with you — which is why every week of this book ends with a reflective task, and why personal therapy and supervision are professional requirements, not luxuries.

> **CASE**
> Mrs Okonkwo brings her 9-year-old son, Ebuka, for "stubbornness". In the first ten minutes she mentions, twice, that his father "is never home". The linear frame says: assess and treat Ebuka's behaviour. The systemic frame says: ask who else is affected by the behaviour, what happens after it, and what would change in the household if it stopped. The second question is not a rejection of the first; it is a widening of the field in which the first can be treated.

1.5 Systems as a way of thinking

Students often assume "system" is jargon for "family". It is not. A system is any set of elements whose interaction produces effects none of the elements produces alone. Ludwig von Bertalanffy's general system theory (1968), Norbert Wiener's cybernetics (1948) and the communications research at Palo Alto gave the field three tools, and they are still the three tools.

Feedback. A system regulates itself through loops. **Negative feedback** reduces deviation and restores the previous state — the family that pulls a member back whenever they move too far, the couple whose argument returns to the same sentence. **Positive feedback** amplifies deviation and produces change or escalation — the quarrel that grows, the affair that is discovered, the child who leaves. Note that the words are not evaluative: negative feedback is not bad, positive is not good. Most clinical problems are stuck negative-feedback loops with high cost; most crises are positive-feedback loops that have run away.

Homeostasis and morphostasis. Systems resist change in order to remain themselves. When a family comes to therapy, two processes are always running: the pressure to solve the problem and the pressure to keep the system intact. This is why families sometimes seem to sabotage their own treatment, and why the therapist who moves too fast loses the family. The technical answer is to pace: introduce change at a rate the system can absorb, and check that each change is stable before the next.

Rules and punctuation. Watzlawick, Beavin and Jackson's Pragmatics of Human Communication (1967) gave the field its most quoted propositions: one cannot not

communicate; every communication has a content and a relationship level; relationships are defined by punctuation of sequences; humans communicate digitally (words) and analogically (behaviour, tone, gesture). The idea of **punctuation** is the most clinically valuable. Each partner punctuates the same sequence differently: she says "he goes silent, so I get loud"; he says "she gets loud, so I go silent". Both are describing the same loop from different points on it, and each punctuation makes the other the cause. Therapy begins when the loop, rather than either partner, becomes the object of attention.

Structure. Minuchin added what communication theory lacked: an account of organisation. Families have subsystems (parental, sibling, couple), boundaries (clear, diffuse, rigid), hierarchies, alliances and coalitions. A child who is in a coalition with one parent against the other is not "manipulative"; the child is holding a structural position that the adults' conflict has created. Structure gives the therapist something to see in the seating plan and something to change in the session.

Meaning. The later schools — Milan, narrative, collaborative — pushed the field from pattern to interpretation. If the system is a set of interactions, it is also a set of stories about those interactions. A family that has decided "our son is the problem" has organised its attention, its conversations and its hopes around that sentence. Change the sentence and the interactions move; move the interactions and the sentence loses its evidence.

> **PRACTICAL**
> Choose an ordinary recurring household event: the school run, Sunday lunch, the nightly argument about homework. Draw it as a loop with four to six nodes, each node a behaviour, with arrows showing what follows what. Then mark: where is the negative feedback (what restores the previous state)? Where is the positive feedback (what escalates)? Where does each participant punctuate the loop? Bring the drawing to the lab; you will redraw it after hearing someone else's account of the same event.

1.11a What the evidence says, in one page

Students are often told either that family therapy "works" or that the evidence is contested. Both are unhelpful. Here is what a careful reading of the outcome literature supports, stated with the hedge each claim requires.

Family and couple therapy outperform no treatment, and generally match individual treatment for relational problems. Meta-analyses of couple and family therapy trials report effect sizes in the moderate range — roughly half a standard deviation to eight-tenths — against no-treatment and wait-list controls, with the larger effects for couple distress, child conduct problems, and adolescent substance use. Effects are smaller and less consistent against credible active comparators, which is what you would expect if the specific model matters less than the common structure of good therapy.

The model explains less of the variance than the alliance. The most robust finding in psychotherapy research, replicated across modalities, is that the therapeutic alliance predicts outcome better than the technical ingredients of any particular school. In couple

and family work the alliance is more complicated than in individual work, because there is more than one alliance to build and they can pull against each other: siding with one partner to engage them alienates the other, and a determined even-handedness can leave both feeling unheard. This is why Week 6 of this book spends two sessions on joining, and why your assessed skill in this course includes your ability to hold two alliances at once.

Common factors do a lot of the work. Client factors (severity, chronicity, social support, motivation), the alliance, the therapist's skill and the expectancy generated by a credible rationale account for a large share of change. The practical implication is not that technique is irrelevant but that technique is delivered through a relationship, and a technique delivered through a poor relationship is inert or harmful.

Dose and dropout matter more than most trainees think. A substantial proportion of families attend one session and never return; the first session is therefore an outcome event, not a preliminary. Retention is predicted by early alliance, by the fit between the therapist's explanation and the family's own understanding, and by practicalities — travel, cost, timing, childcare — that a therapist who ignores them will mistake for resistance.

Evidence is unevenly distributed across problems. Couple therapy for relationship distress, behavioural parent training for conduct problems, family-based treatment for adolescent eating disorders, multidimensional family therapy for adolescent substance use, and systemic work with chronic illness in children have reasonably strong support. Evidence for some popular ideas — mechanical use of paradox, unexamined "dysfunctional family" typologies, polyvagal explanations treated as established mechanism — is much weaker. Learning to distinguish these is part of professional formation, and MFT 705 and MFT 721 teach you to read the literature rather than the marketing.

> **CAUTION**
> Do not let the common-factors literature become an excuse for not learning a model. "The alliance is what matters" is true and is also the sentence most often used by trainees who have not yet learned to do anything. You need a model precise enough to be taught, supervised and evaluated, and a relationship good enough for the model to reach the family. Neither substitutes for the other.

1.6 First contact: three openings, annotated

The relational frame is not announced, it is enacted. Three openings show what it looks like when a therapist begins relationally in the first five minutes — before any genogram, any diagnosis, any technique.

Opening A — from the referred person to the referral system.

> **THERAPIST:**
> Before we start, tell me how this appointment came about. Who first said something needed to change, and who agreed? **Mrs Okonkwo:** The school called me. His teacher said he refuses to write anything. **Therapist:** And when you told your husband, what did he say? **Mrs Okonkwo:** (pause) He said I should handle it. He is not around. **Therapist:** So the school spoke to you, you spoke to your husband, and here you are with Ebuka. Who else in the family knows you are here today?

Note what the therapist has done. She has not asked about the symptom at all. She has mapped the **referral pathway**, which is itself a relational fact: who is worried, who is not, who carries the problem, who was told and who was not. She has also discovered, in four questions, the sentence that will organise the assessment: he said I should handle it. That sentence is not a complaint about a husband. It is a description of a household in which one adult holds all the worry, and a child's symptom sits in the space where the other adult would be.

Opening B — from the symptom to the sequence.

> **THERAPIST:**
> Tell me about the last time it happened. Not the worst time — the most recent. **Mrs Okonkwo:** Yesterday morning. He would not get out of bed. I called him three times, then I started shouting, then he got up and stood in the bathroom for twenty minutes. **Therapist:** And then? **Mrs Okonkwo:** Then I drove him late and I was angry all day. **Therapist:** What did Ebuka do when you were angry all day? **Mrs Okonkwo:** He was very quiet. He even made me tea.

The sequence is now visible: refusal, escalation, compliance, and then **repair initiated by the child**. That is the loop. The therapist did not need to interpret it. She asked for a specific episode and then asked "and then?" until the loop closed. This is the single most useful micro-skill in the first session: **episode, not opinion.** Opinions produce character descriptions ("he is stubborn"); episodes produce sequences.

Opening C — from the individual to the room.

> **THERAPIST:**
> (to Ebuka) Your mum says mornings are hard. If I asked her to describe a good morning, what would she say happens? **Ebuka:** (shrugs) She would be happy. **Therapist:** How would she know? What would she see? **Ebuka:** (long pause) My dad would be there.

Three questions, and the child has produced the formulation. The therapist did not ask "how do you feel about your father's absence?" — a question no nine-year-old answers truthfully. She asked a **behavioural question about a third person's perception**, which is easier to answer and much harder to fake. Involving the child as an informant, not a patient, is a structural act: it moves the child out of the identified- patient position and into the family's information system.

What all three openings have in common. Each one moves the unit of attention one step outward — from the person to the pathway, from the event to the sequence, from the individual to the room — and each does so with a question that is answerable. That is the whole craft of a first session in miniature. The student who can do these three moves in the first ten minutes will get a formulation. The student who cannot will get a history.

1.7 The Okonkwo case, fully worked

Referral. Ebuka, 9, referred by his school for "defiance and refusal to write". Six weeks of refusing to complete written work; two episodes of leaving the classroom. Class teacher describes him as "stubborn and rude". Mother reports he is "fine at home, except mornings". Father did not attend.

What the linear frame produces. A differential diagnosis: oppositional defiant disorder versus a specific learning difficulty (writing), versus anxiety, versus an attention problem. An assessment plan: psychometric testing, teacher rating scales, classroom observation, possibly a paediatric review. A treatment plan: behavioural contract, reward chart, parent training in commands and consequences. This is not wrong. It is incomplete in a way that will matter, because the most important information in this family is not about Ebuka's writing.

What the systemic frame adds. Four moves, in order.

Move 1 — the referral pathway. Who is worried? The school, then the mother. Who is not in the room? The father. Who decided that the mother should manage it? The father, according to the mother. The first structural fact: **the parental subsystem is not operating as a subsystem.** One adult holds the worry, the other holds the distance.

Move 2 — the sequence. Mornings: refusal, three calls, shouting, compliance, lateness, a day of maternal anger, evening reparation initiated by the child. The second structural fact: **the child regulates the mother's emotional state.** He absorbs her anger and then repairs it. A nine-year-old is doing the work of a partner.

Move 3 — the function of the symptom. What would change at home if Ebuka got up cheerfully and wrote fluently? The mornings would be calm; the mother's day would be easier; and the father's absence would become a topic rather than a background condition. There is no evidence that anyone wants the child to be symptomatic. There is good evidence that the symptom sits at the exact point where a marital conversation would otherwise occur.

Move 4 — the wider system. School, church, extended family. In this case the maternal grandmother is mentioned twice and the paternal aunt once. In many Nigerian households the grandmother is a co-parent and a court of appeal; leaving her out of the assessment is not neutrality, it is an omission.

The formulation, in one paragraph. Ebuka's refusal to write is maintained by a morning sequence in which escalation reliably produces compliance and in which the child then repairs his mother's distress. That sequence is itself maintained by a household in which one parent carries all the worry and the other is absent, and by a school system that has defined the problem as a defect in the child. The symptom is not caused by the

marriage, and nobody is to blame; but the symptom is located where the marriage would otherwise be discussed, and it will be difficult to resolve without that conversation becoming possible.

The plan that follows. Conjoint sessions including the father (with an explicit invitation framed as expertise rather than blame: "I need your view of what happens in the mornings; your wife and I are working from one account"). A behavioural component for the mornings, because it works and because success builds the parents' confidence in themselves as a team. A separate conversation with the parents about the marriage, held only when both are willing. Liaison with the school to reframe "defiance" as "a problem we are assessing", which reduces the pressure that feeds the loop.

> **TASK**
> Rewrite this case as you would present it in a multidisciplinary team meeting in forty seconds, without using the word "systemic" and without blaming either parent. Then rewrite it for the parents themselves. The two versions should differ in vocabulary, not in content.

1.8 Where the profession sits

Students enter training with a blurred map of the mental health professions. In Nigeria, as in most places, the practical differences matter for referral, for legal standing, and for what you are allowed to do.

Profession	Core unit	Typical training	What they usually do with a struggling family
Psychiatry	The patient, medically	Medical degree, then residency	Diagnose, prescribe, admit; refer for therapy
Clinical psychology	The individual	Doctorate or master's plus internship	Assess, formulate, deliver individual therapy
Counselling psychology	The individual in context	Master's or doctorate	Individual and group counselling, some couple work
Social work	The person in their environment	Degree plus registration	Case management, child protection, family support
Marriage and family therapy	The relationship	Master's or doctorate in MFT	Conjoint, family and couple therapy; relational formulation

The distinctive contribution is not a technique. Clinical psychologists do behavioural couple work; psychiatrists do family meetings; social workers do family support. The distinctive contribution is the **relational formulation** — the disciplined habit of locating the problem in the space between people, and the training in interventions that change that space. A therapist who can only see individuals will treat a family by treating its members one at a time and will be genuinely puzzled when the symptom returns.

Settings in which the work happens. Outpatient clinics and private practice; hospitals, where family meetings follow diagnoses that reorganise households; schools, where the referral pathway usually begins; NGOs and humanitarian settings, where family

separation, displacement and bereavement are the presenting context; faith settings, where pastors, imams and church counsellors are often the first and sometimes the only port of call; and courts and child protection services, where the therapist's opinion may be read by a judge. Each setting changes the ethics (see MFT 704), the assessment (MFT 707) and even the language you use.

Scope of practice. Three boundaries worth stating on the first day of training. First, family therapists do not prescribe; any question about medication is a referral question, and the referral should be made without implying that medication is a failure. Second, family therapists do not give legal advice; they provide clinical opinion and, where required, reports, and they tell families to obtain a lawyer (see MFT 724). Third, family therapists do not practise beyond their competence — and competence is specific: adult couple work is not child work, child work is not forensic work, and neither is trauma processing without specific training (MFT 711, MFT 714).

> **AUDIT**
> Write down, in one sentence each, what you would do and would not do if a family asked you to (a) advise whether the husband can legally take a second wife, (b) tell the court which parent should have custody, (c) prescribe something for the child's sleep. Bring the three sentences to the lab.

1.9 Culture, faith and class in the first meeting

The relational frame is not culturally neutral, and pretending otherwise is its own kind of arrogance. Three adjustments matter from the first session in most Nigerian consulting rooms.

Kinship is wider than the household. A genogram that stops at the nuclear family will miss the grandmother who raised the child for three years, the uncle who pays the school fees and therefore has standing, the aunt who lives with the family and disciplines the children, and the cousin whose presence has changed the sleeping arrangements. Ask who is involved, not who lives there. The distinction between household and family is one of the most practically useful in the whole programme.

Faith is a resource and a referral system, not a rival. Families commonly arrive having already seen a pastor, an imam, a traditional healer or all three. The therapist's task is not to adjudicate but to coordinate: what did the prayer, the deliverance, the fasting, the herbal treatment do? What was helpful? What was frightening? What does the family believe is happening spiritually? A family that believes the problem is spiritual and a therapist who believes it is relational can still work together if the therapist takes the belief seriously as a meaning in the system, which is exactly what it is.

Class shapes what is possible. A recommendation to reduce working hours is meaningless to a family with two jobs and no childcare. A recommendation to attend weekly sessions is meaningless to a family who travel four hours. A recommendation to "talk to your husband" is meaningless in a household where his mother is the decision-maker. Practical recommendations fail not because families are resistant but

because the therapist prescribed from a life the family does not have. The discipline is to ask, before prescribing: what would have to be true in your week for this to happen? The answer is usually the real treatment plan.

> **CAUTION**
> Do not treat cultural deference as consent. A wife who says "I will do whatever my husband decides" may be expressing a genuine value, or may be signalling that she cannot speak safely. The difference is discovered by seeing her alone at least once, and by asking about safety in the standard way — not by assuming either interpretation.

1.10 Six errors that begin in week one

These are the mistakes students actually make in their first role-plays, and each one is a failure of the relational frame rather than a failure of technique.

1. **The single-informant assessment.** You interview the mother, form a picture, and never test it. Fix: no relational formulation without at least two informants, and no family assessment without asking who is missing.
2. **The character formulation.** "He is oppositional." "She is enmeshed." These are descriptions of persons disguised as systemic language. Fix: every formulation must contain at least one sequence ("when X, then Y, then Z") and at least one context ("in the presence of…").
3. **Premature reassurance.** "I'm sure he loves you." It closes the exploration and hands the therapist's opinion to a family that needs its own. Fix: acknowledge the experience, ask for the evidence, keep the question open.
4. **The alliance slide.** You begin to like one member more than another and your questions begin to build the case for that person. Fix: track your questions across a session (record it) and count how many were addressed to each person and whose account each question elaborated.
5. **The technique-first session.** You arrive with a genogram to draw, a technique to demonstrate, a model to apply — and the family's actual concern is never heard. Fix: the first session belongs to the family's account, not to the therapist's plan.
6. **The safety omission.** You conduct a full conjoint assessment without ever asking about violence. Fix: every first session includes a private screen for harm to self, harm to others, abuse of children and intimate partner violence, conducted in a way that makes disclosure possible (see MFT 704 and MFT 712).

> **REFLECT**
> Which of the six are you most likely to commit? Not in theory: in your last conversation with someone who was struggling. Write the answer down. You will be asked to revisit it in Week 14.

1.11 Laboratory: the widening question

The week's practical is a triad drill in which the therapist may only ask questions that include another person. It looks simple and it is not: most students discover that their natural question is a question about an individual, and that widening feels artificial for the first twenty minutes.

Setup. Groups of three. Roles rotate every eight minutes, so each person is therapist once. One person brings a real but non-clinical difficulty — a disagreement with a flatmate, a difficult decision about a sibling, a strain with a colleague. No clinical material, no disclosure that would be regretted.

Rules for the therapist.

1. No statements, interpretations or advice — questions only.
2. Every question must include a third party or a relationship: "who notices…", "what does your sister do when…", "who would disagree…", "what happens between you after…".
3. One question at a time, with silence after each.
4. Eight minutes, then stop whether or not the conversation feels finished.

Observer's task. Two columns on one sheet: **W** (questions that widened the field) and **N** (questions that narrowed it back to the individual). Tally, then quote the single most useful widening question and the single most narrowing one.

Debrief questions. What did the client notice about their own description when it was widened? Which widening felt intrusive, and why? What did the therapist want to say but could not? What happened to the client's tone when a third person entered the story?

Marking rubric (used in the Week 6 skills gate).

Criterion	Weight	What full marks looks like
Proportion of widening questions	30%	More than 80% of questions include another person or a relationship
Question quality	25%	Open, specific, answerable; no double questions; no embedded advice
Pacing and silence	20%	Roughly one question per 30–45 seconds; client speaks more than therapist
Use of the client's words	15%	At least three questions reuse the client's own phrasing
Reflexivity in debrief	10%	Can name what was hard, what was tempting, what they avoided

> **DRILL**
> Record a five-minute role-play on your phone. Count your questions. Then count how many contain a third person. Most first attempts are around one in ten. The target is eight in ten, and it takes about three hours of deliberate practice to get there.

1.12 Reflective task

Write 500 words on the last significant conflict in your own family, then rewrite it from the point of view of the person you understood least. Note what changed in your body as you wrote. Keep both versions; you will return to them in Week 14, when you write your emerging clinical stance, and you will find that the second version contains the therapist you are becoming.

Two rules for this task. Do not show it to the person concerned, and do not bring the person's name into the seminar. The purpose is to develop the capacity to hold more than one punctuation of the same sequence at once — which is precisely what you will ask families to do.

1.13 Self-test

Six questions, answers below. If you cannot answer 4 and 5 without notes, reread 1.5.

1. Define negative and positive feedback, and give one clinical example of each.
2. Why is "punctuation" clinically useful?
3. State the double-bind hypothesis and its current scientific status.
4. What is symptom substitution, and what does it imply for treatment?
5. Name the five claims of the relational frame, in order.
6. What are the four consequences of treating the relationship as the client?

Answers. 1. Negative feedback reduces deviation and restores a prior state (a family pulling a member back from independence); positive feedback amplifies deviation (an argument that escalates through counter-complaint). 2. Because each participant's punctuation makes the other appear to be the cause; the therapist who makes punctuation visible turns blame into a loop both can act on. 3. A person receives contradictory messages at different logical levels, cannot comment on the contradiction and cannot leave the field; it is historically important and not a supported causal explanation of schizophrenia. 4. The observation that removing a symptom is often followed by a new symptom elsewhere in the system; it implies that treatment must change the system, not only the symptom. 5. Behaviour is patterned; patterns are maintained by consequences rather than causes; meaning is negotiated; symptoms can serve the system; the observer is inside the observed system. 6. The unit of assessment, the unit of intervention, the definition of success, and the therapist's position.

1.14 Readings for this week

Read the first two before the lecture; the rest are for the assignment.

- **Bateson, Jackson, Haley & Weakland (1956)**, "Toward a theory of schizophrenia", Behavioral Science. Read it as a historical document and notice how carefully the authors hedge.
- **Watzlawick, Beavin & Jackson (1967)**, Pragmatics of Human Communication, chapters 1–2. The axioms, in the original.

- **Nichols & Schwartz**, Family Therapy: Concepts and Methods, chapter 1. The best single overview of the field's history.
- **Becvar & Becvar**, Family Therapy: A Systemic Integration, chapters 3–5. On cybernetics and second-order thinking.
- **Hoffman (1985)**, "Beyond power and control", Family Systems Medicine. The turn to second-order cybernetics, written by a participant.
- **Minuchin (1974)**, Families and Family Therapy, chapter 2. Structure, in Minuchin's own voice.

1.6a An extended transcript, annotated

Role-plays teach faster than principles. Below is a twelve-turn excerpt from a first session with a couple who present with "we cannot communicate". The therapist is a trainee in her second term. Read the transcript, cover the annotations, and decide what you would have asked next. Then read the annotations.

> **T1 THERAPIST:**
> What would you like me to understand first? **T2 Folake:** He doesn't talk to me. He comes home, eats, watches television, sleeps. I am alone in this house. **T3 Therapist:** (to Dele) What do you think your wife means when she says she is alone? **T4 Dele:** I don't know. I work. I am tired. She is not alone, there are three children in the house. **T5 Therapist:** Folake, what do you do when he is watching television? **T6 Folake:** I stand there. Sometimes I ask him something and he says "mm". **T7 Therapist:** And what happens then? **T8 Folake:** I get angry. I say something sharp. Then he goes to bed. **T9 Therapist:** Dele, when she says something sharp, what goes through your mind? **T10 Dele:** That nothing I do is enough. So I stop. **T11 Therapist:** And when you stop, Folake, what happens to the anger? **T12 Folake:** It grows. And then I cannot sleep and I am tired the next day and the children see me crying.

Annotations.

T1 is a neutral opening that hands the agenda to the couple without inviting either partner to be the complainant. Compare "What is the problem?" — which usually produces one person's problem statement and positions the other as the problem.

T3 is the first systemic move: instead of asking Dele to defend himself, the therapist asks him to **interpret his wife**, which requires him to engage with her experience rather than his own. It also reveals whether he has a theory of her mind at all. He does not: "I don't know" is honest and important.

T5 is an **episode question** and it is doing three things at once. It bypasses the argument about whether she is alone (unwinnable), it specifies a moment (television, evening), and it puts the therapist physically in the room with them. Students who ask "why do you feel alone?" get an explanation; students who ask "what do you do when he is watching television?" get the behaviour that maintains the loneliness.

T7, "and then?", is the single most productive two-word intervention in family therapy. It builds the sequence one link at a time and stops the therapist from doing the formulating.

T9 takes the same event and asks for the **other partner's internal sequence**, which turns two monologues into one loop. Note that the therapist does not challenge Dele's account ("three children in the house" is not an answer to loneliness, but arguing about it would lose him). She lets the sequence do the work.

T10 is the pivot of the session. "Nothing I do is enough, so I stop" is a complete formulation of Dele's side of the loop, offered by Dele. Nothing the therapist could have said would have been as convincing or as usable.

T11 closes the loop by returning to Folake with the consequence of his withdrawal. At T12 she supplies it: the anger grows, sleep is lost, the children see her crying. The loop is now on the table, described entirely in the couple's own words, and neither partner has been blamed.

What the therapist has **not** done in twelve turns is worth listing, because trainees over-value these moves: she has not asked about the history of the marriage, has not asked how they met, has not asked about sex, has not offered an interpretation, has not normalised, has not asked either partner to change anything, and has not used the word "communication". Every one of those is legitimate; none of them was needed to establish the relational frame in the first ten minutes.

> **PRACTICAL**
> In pairs, take turns being the therapist with this transcript. Cover T3 to T12 and improvise your own next question at each point. Then compare with the original. Where did you ask for an opinion rather than an episode? Where did you reassure? Where did you take a side without noticing?

1.10a Three punctuations of one quarrel

The same sequence can be punctuated at least three ways, and each punctuation licenses a different intervention. Take the quarrel the couple above actually have.

Punctuation 1 — the character story. "He is cold and withdrawn; I am affectionate and he rejects me." What it licenses: an appeal to Dele to change, a diagnosis of Dele (avoidant, depressive, possibly autistic), and a treatment that works on Dele. What it costs: Folake's contribution disappears, Dele becomes a project rather than a partner, and Dele — who already believes nothing he does is enough — experiences therapy as one more arena in which he fails.

Punctuation 2 — the mirror story. "She criticises; I withdraw; she criticises more." What it licenses: a circular formulation, a sequence map, and interventions aimed at the loop (interrupting the escalation, slowing the exchange, rehearsing a different response to criticism). What it costs: the loop can become an abstraction that hides the asymmetry of power and the real losses — his hours, her sleeplessness, the children's exposure.

Punctuation 3 — the meaning story. "She is asking for evidence that she matters; he is protecting himself from evidence that he fails." What it licenses: work on attachment, on the meanings each assigns to the other's behaviour, and on the moment of turning toward or away. What it costs: meaning work without behaviour change can become insight that never reaches the household.

A competent therapist holds all three and chooses deliberately, usually sequencing them: the loop first (because it lowers blame), the meaning second (because it explains why the loop is so adhesive), and the character story never as a formulation, only as each partner's experience to be listened to. This pluralism — several punctuations available, one chosen for a reason — is what distinguishes a systemic clinician from someone who has memorised a model.

> **DEBATE**
> "Circular formulations are kinder but less true." Fifteen minutes. Note that the strongest argument for circularity is not moral but empirical: linear accounts of complex interaction are almost always wrong about causation, even when they are right about blame.

1.13a Examination question with model answer

Question (20 marks). "Family therapy is a way of seeing, not a set of techniques." Discuss, with reference to the historical development of the field and to at least one clinical example.

Model answer, in note form, with the markers' expectations visible.

Introduction (2 marks). State the claim in your own words: the relational frame is an epistemological commitment — a claim about the unit of analysis and the nature of causation — and techniques are downstream of it. Signal the structure of the answer: history, epistemology, clinical example, limits.

History (6 marks). Three research programmes converged on the same failure: Bateson's group and the double bind; Lidz and Wynne on family organisation around psychosis; the child guidance movement and symptom substitution. The aetiological claims of the 1950s were largely wrong and you should say so; what survived is the methodological insight that sequences carry information individuals do not. Trace the schools as answers to "what is the unit?" — Palo Alto (the sequence), Bowen (the generations), Minuchin (the structure), Milan (the meaning), Milwaukee (the solution), Adelaide (the story).

Epistemology (6 marks). Circular versus linear causality; feedback and homeostasis; punctuation; second-order cybernetics and the therapist's position. Use Watzlawick's axioms precisely — content and relationship levels, digital and analogic communication — and show what each buys clinically. Demonstrate that you understand the difference between an ecological claim (the system is the unit of assessment) and a causal claim (the system causes the symptom), and reject the second.

Clinical example (4 marks). The strongest answers use one case throughout rather than several in passing. The Okonkwo case works: a nine-year-old's school refusal, a morning

sequence, a parental subsystem that is not operating, and a formulation that no single-informant assessment could have produced. Show what the relational frame let you see and what it let you do.

Limits (2 marks). Name them honestly: the frame can obscure individual biology, trauma and temperament; it can be used to distribute responsibility in ways that leave an abusive member unaccountable; it can become a language that describes loops without ever changing them. Note the feminist critique of neutrality and the evidence that the alliance — not the model — predicts much of the outcome.

Common ways to lose marks. Describing techniques without explaining the frame; treating "systemic" as a synonym for "family"; repeating the double-bind hypothesis as if it were current; failing to give a clinical example at all; writing about circular causality without ever defining feedback.

1.13b What "good" looks like at the end of week one

A checklist you can use on yourself before Week 2. Tick only what you can do without notes.

- ■ Explain, in ninety seconds, why the field moved from the individual to the relationship, using three historical examples and one honest caveat about the science of the 1950s.
- ■ Define negative and positive feedback and give a clinical example of each that you have actually seen.
- ■ Explain punctuation to a couple without using the word "punctuation".
- ■ Turn three opinion questions into episode questions, out loud, without hesitation.
- ■ State the four consequences of treating the relationship as the client, and give one practical implication of each for a first session.
- ■ Describe the difference between a linear and a circular formulation using the same case twice.
- ■ Name the three professional boundaries from 1.8 and what you would say to a family that crossed them.
- ■ Ask about safety in a first session without it sounding like an accusation or an afterthought.

Week 2 — Linear and circular causality

2.1 The lecture in ninety minutes

Last week asked who is the client. This week asks a harder question: **what kind of thing is a cause?** It is the single most consequential idea in the programme, because everything downstream — the formulation, the questions you ask, what you count as progress, how you write a report for a court — depends on whether you think in lines or in loops.

Students usually arrive believing they already understand this. They can define circular causality in a sentence: "each person's behaviour causes the other's." Then they conduct a role-play in which every question they ask is a search for who started it. The gap between being able to say it and being able to do it is the work of this week.

Minutes	Segment	What the lecturer does	What students do
0–10	Two sentences	Reads a case in a linear account, then in a circular account	Mark every causal verb in both
10–25	The philosophy nobody teaches	Aristotle's four causes, Hume, Mills, why "cause" is plural (2.2)	Sort five clinical explanations into cause types
25–45	Feedback, formally	Loop diagrams, delay, gain, thresholds (2.3–2.4)	Draw the same family as two different loops
45–60	Punctuation, again	The same quarrel punctuated three ways (2.5)	Identify their own punctuation habit
60–75	Circular questioning	Live demonstration, then triads (2.6)	Ask three circular questions each
75–90	Hypothesis discipline	How to hold a hypothesis without becoming its servant (2.7)	Write one hypothesis, then one disconfirming question

The lecture has a deliberate shape: philosophy first, engineering second, clinical craft third. Students who skip the philosophy conclude that circular causality is a nicer way of saying "we are all responsible". Students who skip the engineering cannot tell a loop from a list.

2.2 What a cause is: four traditions you will use without knowing

Family therapy inherited a muddle about causation and never fully cleaned it up. The muddle is worth untangling, because most of the field's disagreements about evidence, responsibility and blame are disagreements about what counts as a cause.

Aristotle's four causes. Aristotle distinguished the material cause (what something is made of), the efficient cause (what set it in motion), the formal cause (the pattern it realises) and the final cause (the purpose it serves). A wooden chair: wood, a carpenter, a design, the purpose of sitting. Now apply the scheme to a symptom. A boy's school refusal: his anxiety (material), a frightening event (efficient), a pattern of family accommodation (formal), and the function the refusal serves in the household (final). Most clinical arguments are people defending one of these four while denying the others. The systemic tradition is chiefly interested in the formal and final causes — the pattern and the function — which is exactly why it seems to slight the efficient cause (the event that started it) and infuriates colleagues who want to know what happened.

Hume and the regularity theory. A cause is an event constantly conjoined with another, temporally prior, and contiguous with it. This is the model implicit in most medical training and in most of what patients believe. It works well for infections and badly for families, because in families the "effect" is usually also the "cause", arriving before and after in alternation.

Mill's methods. Agreement, difference, concomitant variation. These underwrite the randomised trial, and they are why the trial remains the best tool for the question "does this treatment cause improvement?" They are much weaker for the question "what maintains this pattern in this family?", where the relevant variation cannot be manipulated.

Systems and constitutive causation. In a system, the state of each element is partly constituted by its relations to the others. A thermostat is not caused to switch by the temperature in the way a billiard ball is caused to move by another; the switching is what the system does. Family therapists use this sense when they say that the pursuit and the withdrawal "cause" each other: not that A pushes B and B pushes A in a chain, but that the two behaviours are what they are in virtue of the loop they form.

> **EXERCISE**
> Take the sentence "his drinking broke up the marriage". Rewrite it four times, once for each Aristotelian cause. Then decide which of your four sentences a court would want, which a wife would want, and which would actually help in session.

Two consequences follow, and students should write them down.

First, circularity is not a moral claim. "We are both in the loop" does not mean "we are equally responsible", and it certainly does not mean "the victim is complicit". A man who is violent and a woman who placates him are in a loop, and only one of them is doing the violence. Confusing description with responsibility is the most serious error in the systemic literature, and the feminist critique of the 1980s — developed by Hare-Mustin, Goldner, Bograd and others — was right about it. The corrective is not to abandon circularity but to pair it with an explicit account of power: who has the resources, who can leave, who is believed, whose account is treated as the account.

Second, circularity is a stance, not a finding. You cannot observe a loop from outside; you can only offer a description of a loop from a position inside it. That is second-order cybernetics in one line, and it means your circular formulation is a hypothesis with an author, not a fact with a discoverer.

2.3 Feedback, formally

The engineering vocabulary is not decoration. It gives you words for things you can otherwise only gesture at, and the words make the difference between a formulation that guides intervention and one that merely sounds sophisticated.

Loop, not line. A loop has a variable, a sensor, a comparison with a reference value, and an effector. In a family: the variable might be proximity between the couple; the sensor is each partner's attention to the other; the reference value is an implicit standard of how close they should be; the effector is the behaviour that moves them. This sounds mechanical and is not: the reference values are moral and historical, inherited from the families the partners grew up in.

Negative feedback. Deviation is detected and reduced. The system returns to its set point. Clinically: the family that pulls the adolescent back whenever she separates; the

couple whose argument always returns to the same unresolved sentence; the mother whose anxiety rises when the household is calm, and who finds a problem to restore the familiar tension. Note the crucial point: **negative feedback produces stability, and stability is not always health.**

Positive feedback. Deviation is amplified. Clinically: the argument that escalates because each response is experienced as an attack; the affair discovered, denied, discovered again; the child's school refusal that produces maternal anxiety that produces more refusal. Positive feedback produces change, and change is not always growth. Most crises are runaway positive loops; most chronic presentations are locked negative loops.

Delay. The most under-taught concept in the field. Systems respond to yesterday's state, not today's. A wife raises a complaint on Monday; the husband responds on Thursday with a small act of help; she has by then concluded he does not care and does not notice the help. Delay is why good interventions often look as though they failed: the change is in the pipeline, and the therapist who panics at session four and changes approach destroys the very feedback they needed to see. Rule of thumb: **give a structural intervention three sessions before judging it.**

Gain. How much a system responds to a small deviation. High-gain systems escalate fast and are fragile; low-gain systems are stable and can be rigid. A high-gain couple needs the therapist to slow the exchange and lower the volume; a low-gain family needs the therapist to introduce novelty, raise the emotional temperature slightly, and use enactment. This is the practical payoff of the vocabulary: gain tells you whether to accelerate or decelerate.

Thresholds and hysteresis. Systems do not change smoothly; they flip. A family tolerates a behaviour for years and then, at a threshold, reorganises around it — the daughter's disclosure that triggers a family schism, the debt that ends the pretence of solvency. Hysteresis means the threshold for going one way is not the threshold for coming back: it is easier to enter a crisis than to leave it, and families often need help to cross back.

> **PRACTICAL**
> Draw one family twice. First as a negative-feedback loop with a labelled set point: what state does this family return to, and how does it get there? Then as a positive-feedback loop: what is amplifying, and what would a threshold for change look like? Ten minutes, both drawings, no words allowed beyond labels.

2.4 Three ways of drawing the same family

The Adeyemi family: Amara, 16, has refused school for six weeks. Her mother has depression and is on medication. Her father was made redundant fourteen months ago and drinks in the evenings. There is a younger brother, 11.

Drawing one — the linear account. Redundancy → paternal drinking → marital conflict → maternal depression → Amara's caregiving and anxiety → school refusal. Every arrow points one way. This drawing is true as far as it goes, and it is what a referral letter

usually contains. It is also useless as a treatment plan, because every arrow points at a cause the therapist cannot move, and the only intervention it licenses is at Amara.

Drawing two — the circular account. Amara's refusal keeps her at home; her presence at home reduces the parents' opportunity to argue; the reduction in argument lowers the mother's distress; the mother's lowered distress makes Amara's presence feel necessary; the father's drinking continues in the space that the parental conflict has vacated. No single arrow is the cause; each arrow maintains the next. This drawing is also true, and it is actionable: the loop has four places where it could be interrupted.

Drawing three — the power account. Overlay resources and legitimacy: who earns, who decides, who is believed, who can leave, whose distress is taken seriously. The father's drinking is not neutralised by being "part of a loop": it is a behaviour with a cost, exercised by the person with the most structural power in the household. The mother's depression constrains her capacity to act. Amara has the least power and the most symptomatic expression. The overlay changes what the therapist says: the mother is not "enmeshed", she is exhausted and unsupported; the father is not "in a loop", he is a man who is drinking and needs to be asked to stop, with the consequences named.

What the three drawings teach. A formulation is a choice of drawing for a purpose. The linear drawing is good for history and for medico-legal chronology; the circular drawing is good for intervention design and for lowering blame; the power drawing is good for ethics, safety and responsibility. A competent clinician keeps all three and says which they are using and why. A weak clinician uses the circular drawing because it is the house style and then cannot understand why the wife in the violent marriage is not helped by a conversation about mutual escalation.

> **CAUTION**
> If there is violence, the circular drawing must never be used in the room as the primary formulation until safety has been established and responsibility assigned. Nothing in this week's material licenses the sentence "you are both keeping the cycle going" to a woman who has been hit. See MFT 704, MFT 712 and MFT 714 for the full protocol.

2.4a A worked loop, with numbers

Circular accounts are often criticised for being unfalsifiable. They need not be. Any loop can be given rough magnitudes, and doing so changes what you notice.

Take Loop B from the Adeyemi case: mother's low mood → Amara's caregiving → mother's temporary relief → Amara's increased responsibility → Amara's anxiety about school → school refusal → more time at home.

Assign a plausible scale, in the family's own terms, and mark how confident you are.

Link	Direction	Rough magnitude	Confidence	Evidence
Mother's mood → Amara's caregiving	↑ caregiving as mood falls	Large	High	Both describe it; it happens most days

Link	Direction	Rough magnitude	Confidence	Evidence
Caregiving → mother's relief	Relief for hours	Moderate	High	Mother: "she settles me"
Relief → Amara's load	Load grows, no reduction	Moderate	Medium	Described across six weeks
Load → anxiety about leaving	Anxiety rises	Large	Medium	Amara: "I can't settle at school"
Anxiety → refusal	Refusal	Large	High	Directly observed
Refusal → time at home	Six extra hours a day	Large	High	Arithmetic
Time at home → caregiving	Loop closes	Large	High	Session observation

Three things follow, and each is a clinical decision rather than a theoretical one.

First, the loop has a strongest link. The largest, best-evidenced arrows run through time at home. That is why the first intervention addressed the timetable — not because school attendance is a moral good, but because it is the highest-leverage node in the loop as drawn.

Second, magnitudes tell you what to expect from partial change. If caregiving fell by half but the mother's mood did not improve, the loop would reassert within days, because the relief arrow would still be live. This is why single interventions on complex loops fail and why therapists conclude, wrongly, that "the family is resistant". The family is not resisting; the arithmetic is against you.

Third, confidence is part of the formulation. Two of the seven links are medium-confidence. A good therapist names them in supervision and tests them with a question, rather than building a plan on them silently. "I am assuming your daughter's being at home makes your days easier; is that right, or is it more complicated than that?" is not a weak question — it is the question that protects the plan.

> **PRACTICAL**
> Take your own loop drawing from 2.3 and add two columns: magnitude (small/moderate/large) and confidence (low/medium/high). Then mark the single link you would test first in the next session, and write the question you would use to test it.

2.5 Punctuation, worked

Punctuation is the process by which each participant marks a beginning in a continuous sequence, thereby assigning cause. It is not a mistake to be corrected; it is the ordinary operation of a mind trying to make sense of a loop it is inside.

The four standard punctuations in couple work.

1. **The complainant's punctuation.** "I complain because he withdraws." The complaint is a response; the withdrawal is the cause. Intervention: ask the complainant what they do immediately before the withdrawal, in a specific episode.

2. **The withdrawer's punctuation.** "I withdraw because she criticises." The withdrawal is a response; the criticism is the cause. Intervention: ask what they notice in their body immediately before they go quiet, and what they are protecting.
3. **The reciprocity punctuation.** "We wind each other up." This sounds enlightened and often conceals the asymmetry: someone is doing more of the escalating, or someone is more afraid.
4. **The system punctuation.** "The loop between us has a life of its own." Useful therapeutically, but it can become a way of talking about the relationship at the exact moment when someone needs to be accountable for a specific act.

How punctuation is changed in the room. Not by argument. Telling a husband "actually you both do it" does not change his punctuation; it recruits him into defending it. Punctuation changes through **specific episode work**: slow the sequence down until both partners can see the moment where their own action occurred, and let them describe it themselves. In practice this means three moves, which students should rehearse until they are automatic:

Move 1 — narrow the time frame. "Not the usual argument. The last one. Tuesday evening. Start at the point where you were both still in the kitchen."

Move 2 — ask for the moment before. "What were you doing in the thirty seconds before he stood up?" This is the question that gives the complainant back their own agency without blaming them, because it is factual rather than evaluative.

Move 3 — ask what they noticed inside. "What went through your mind when she said that?" This converts a behavioural sequence into an emotional one, which is where change becomes possible.

Done well, the couple arrives at a sentence neither could have said at the start: "I go quiet because I think I have already lost, and then she gets louder because the quiet looks like contempt." That sentence is the treatment target for the rest of the work.

> **DRILL**
> Record a five-minute role-play in which one partner describes a recurring argument. Listen back and count how many times the therapist asks "why" (which invites justification) versus "what happened next" and "what did you notice" (which invite sequence). Targets: no more than one "why" in five minutes; at least six sequence questions.

2.6 Circular questioning

The Milan associates — Mara Selvini Palazzoli, Luigi Boscolo, Gianfranco Cecchin and Giuliana Prata — developed **circular questioning** in the late 1970s as the operational form of systemic thinking: questions designed to elicit differences and relationships between people, rather than facts about individuals. The technique is more than fifty years old and remains the most portable skill in the field, because it works inside any model.

The four families of circular question.

1. **Difference questions.** "Who is most upset by this? Who is least? Who would notice first if it changed?" These map the system's distribution of concern and give every member a position.
2. **Behavioural-effect questions.** "When she cries, what does your father do? And then what does your mother do?" These build the sequence in the room, from several points of view.
3. **Comparison questions.** "Is this worse than it was when your mother was alive? Better than last year?" These locate the problem in time and reveal the family's own baseline.
4. **Hypothetical or future questions.** "If this problem disappeared tomorrow, what would be the first thing each of you noticed? Who would miss it?" The second half of that question is the one that produces the information, and it must be asked gently.

Two more devices worth knowing. The **interviewing-the-interviewer** move — the therapist asks one member to comment on what the therapist has been asking, which reveals the observing system inside the family. And the **positive connotation** — describing the symptom as serving the family's cohesion — which was Milan's way of preventing the family from defending itself against the therapist. Both are powerful and both are easy to misuse: positive connotation applied to violence is a serious error, and interviewing-the-interviewer can feel like a parlour trick if it is not clearly in the service of the family's question.

What makes a circular question good. It is answerable; it concerns a third party; it asks for a difference; and it is asked without a preferred answer. The last criterion is the hardest. A question like "don't you think your mother worries more than your father?" is a statement with a question mark, and families can hear the difference even when students cannot.

> **PRACTICAL**
> In triads, one person describes a family difficulty. The "therapist" must ask eight questions, two from each family of circular question. The observer records which questions produced new information and which produced a repeat of information already given. The correlation with quality is brutal and instructive.

2.6a Reframing: the intervention that follows from circularity

: the intervention that follows from circularity

If the loop is the unit, then the fastest way to change a loop is to change the meaning each member assigns to the other's behaviour, because meaning is what selects the response. **Reframing** is the deliberate provision of a new frame that fits the same facts and supports a different response. It is the most portable intervention in the field and the easiest to do badly.

The structure of a reframe. Three parts: the behaviour as observed (unchanging, factual), the intention or function (new, plausible, benign), and the consequence for the

relationship (which now invites a different response). Example, with a father who works late:

> "You are the person who makes sure this family is provided for, and you do it by being away from it. That has worked for the family's security. What your wife is telling me is that it has also taught your son that a man's place is outside the house. Neither of you wants that lesson."

Note what has happened. The behaviour is unchanged: he works late. The intention is newly stated and creditable: he provides. The consequence is newly visible: the son is learning something. The father is not accused and not excused, and a different response is now available to him.

Five rules for a reframe that works.

1. **It must fit the facts.** A reframe the family experiences as false is worse than no reframe: it damages credibility and closes the topic. If you cannot find a genuinely plausible benign intention, do not invent one — use a difference question instead.
2. **It must be delivered as an offer, not a verdict.** "I wonder whether…" outperforms "What is really happening is…" in almost every family, because it leaves room for the family to correct you, which is itself engagement.
3. **It must be addressed to the person whose behaviour is being reframed, in their presence.** Reframing someone to their partner behind their back is gossip with a therapeutic vocabulary.
4. **It must not absolve harm.** You can reframe the function of a behaviour without reframing away its cost. "He drinks to manage a shame he cannot speak" is a reframe; it does not make the drinking acceptable, and the next sentence must say so.
5. **It must be followed by a task.** A reframe without a next step is a compliment. The loop changes when the family does something different, not when it understands something new.

Reframes that students overuse. "You are both doing the best you can" (true and inert). "Your son's behaviour is a message of love" (often false, and it places an impossible burden on the child). "This is a normal stage" (sometimes true, and sometimes a way of not assessing). Each of these is a sentence that makes the therapist feel kind and the family feel handled.

> **DRILL**
> Write three reframes for the Adeyemi case: one for the mother's depression, one for the father's drinking, one for Amara's refusal. For each, check the five rules explicitly, then read it aloud to a peer who plays the family member and tells you whether it landed as an offer or a verdict.

2.7 Hypotheses: how to hold one without being owned by it

A **systemic hypothesis** is a provisional explanation of how the presenting problem is maintained by the relationships in the system, stated so that it can be wrong. Milan's team formalised the discipline: the team forms a hypothesis before the session, tests it through circular questioning, and revises it, keeping several alive at once.

Three properties of a usable hypothesis.

1. **It is relational.** It mentions at least two people and at least one sequence: "when the father criticises, the mother intervenes, and the son then refuses to speak — which returns the couple to a familiar division of labour."
2. **It is testable in the room.** There is a question whose answer would make you doubt it. If no such question exists, you are holding a belief, not a hypothesis.
3. **It includes the function.** What work does the symptom do for the system? The answer may be "very little, and the family is simply suffering", which is a legitimate finding and should be said out loud.

The hypothesis-discipline drill. Write your hypothesis in one sentence. Then write three questions: one that would support it, one that would complicate it, and one that would refute it. Ask all three. Trainees routinely discover that they only ever ask the first. That habit is the beginning of confirmatory practice, and it is the most common failure of experienced therapists as well as novices.

Hypotheses in a team. Where a reflecting team or a live supervisor is available, the discipline is strongest: the team holds the hypothesis, the therapist stays curious, and the family is spared the weight of being interpreted. Where there is no team, the therapist must build the discipline internally — writing the hypothesis down before the session, and reviewing it after, is not bureaucracy; it is the substitute for a second mind.

> **TASK**
> Take the Adeyemi family. Write three competing hypotheses: one structural, one multigenerational, one strategic. For each, name the single question you would ask first and the observation that would make you abandon it. Bring all three to the lab; you will be asked to defend the one you would bet on, then switch.

2.8 The Adeyemi family, worked: from loop to plan

Referral. Amara, 16, out of school for six weeks. Referred by the school counsellor, who writes: "Amara presents with anxiety and possible depression; family reluctant to engage." Mother attends with Amara. Father "working" and unavailable.

Session one, what actually happens. The mother speaks for twenty minutes. Amara sits with her hood up and says four words. The therapist's temptation, named openly in supervision afterwards, was to get Amara talking — the standard move, and the wrong one, because it would have confirmed the family's map in which Amara is the patient and the mother is the escort. Instead the therapist asked three questions, in this order.

1. "Before Amara stopped going to school, what was happening in the house?" Mother: a long account of her husband's redundancy, her own illness, the money.
2. "Who else in the family knows how bad things have been?" Mother: nobody. Her sister "would only worry". Her husband "knows some of it".
3. "Amara, when your mother is having a bad day, what do you do?" Amara, first full sentence: "I stay with her."

The sequence is now visible, and it took three questions. The daughter's presence at home is not only a symptom; it is the household's arrangement for managing the mother's distress in the absence of another adult. The school refusal is doing work.

Formulation. Three loops, nested.

- **Loop A (parental).** Father's redundancy → shame and drinking → mother's depression → father's further withdrawal (he experiences the household as a place where he fails) → more drinking. This is the primary loop, and it is invisible while the child is the identified patient.
- **Loop B (mother–daughter).** Mother's low mood → Amara's caregiving → mother's temporary relief → Amara's increasing responsibility → Amara's anxiety about leaving → school refusal. This loop is maintained by love and by the absence of another adult, not by pathology.
- **Loop C (family–school).** School pressure → mother's shame → pressure on Amara → Amara's withdrawal → school escalation → more pressure. This loop is powered by an institution's timetable, which is why it is so hard to slow.

What the therapist did next, and why. The plan was sequenced deliberately, and the sequencing is the teachable part.

Step 1 — change the unit of the sessions before changing anything else. The therapist asked for a session with both parents, framed as expertise: "I need your husband's view of what the house is like now; I am working from one account and it is not fair to any of you." Framing the invitation as a request for information rather than a summons to be confronted is the difference between a father who attends and a father who refuses.

Step 2 — give the parents a job that is theirs. Not "spend more time together" (an instruction that will be experienced as another failure) but a specific, small, observable task: both parents to handle the next school letter together, before either of them speaks to Amara about it. The task is structural — it creates a parental subsystem in the presence of the therapist — and it is small enough to succeed.

Step 3 — separate the caregiving from the child. With the mother: who else could be with her on a bad day? The answer produced a sister, a neighbour and a church member. The therapist did not ask the mother to need less; she asked the system to supply more adults.

Step 4 — take the school out of the loop. A single call from the therapist to the school counsellor, reframing "anxiety and reluctance" as "a family in a difficult year, with a plan", reduced the institutional pressure that was feeding Loop C. Ten minutes of professional-to-professional contact changed the family's week.

Step 5 — attend to the father's drinking, on its own terms. Not as a symptom of the marriage. The therapist raised it directly, with the mother present and without moralising: how much, how often, what it does, what he thinks about it. He agreed to a referral for assessment. He did not stop drinking in the course of the work. The family still improved, which is a finding worth holding: improvement is not contingent on every problem being solved.

What happened by session eight. Amara returned to school part-time, with a staged timetable agreed between the parents, the school and the therapist. Her caregiving load was shared. The parents' arguments did not disappear; they became discussable in session, which is a modest and real outcome. The father attended six of eight sessions and was, by his own account, "not fixed, but in the conversation".

What a student should take from the case. Four things. The symptom was doing work, and naming that did not blame the child. The primary loop was the parents', and the presenting problem was the route to it, not a distraction from it. The interventions were sequenced, small, and structural. And not everything was solved — which is what real work looks like and what written case studies too rarely admit.

2.9 Annotated transcript: turning a linear account into a loop

The following excerpt is from the first session, minutes 18–26. The mother has been describing Amara's refusal. Read the annotation after each turn.

> **T1 MOTHER:**
> She just will not go. I have tried everything. Her father says I am too soft with her. **T2 Therapist:** So your husband thinks the answer is firmer handling. What do you think he would say if I asked him why? **T3 Mother:** (pause) He would say I let her wrap me round her finger. He thinks I need her at home. **T4 Therapist:** What makes you say that? **T5 Mother:** Because when she is at home she sits with me. And when she is at school I am on my own all day. **T6 Therapist:** So her being at home helps you. And it also worries you. **T7 Mother:** (crying) Both. I know it is wrong to say that. **T8 Therapist:** It is not wrong. It is the most honest thing said in this room today. Amara, when your mother is crying, what do you do? **T9 Amara:** I get her water. **T10 Therapist:** And what happens to your own day when you are getting her water?

Annotations.

T2 is the pivot of the whole session and it is worth studying closely. The therapist does not ask "are you too soft?" — which would put the mother on trial — nor does she defend the mother. She asks the mother to **report her husband's view and its reasons**, which does three things: it brings the absent father into the room as a voice rather than a criticism; it treats the mother as a reliable observer of her marriage; and it reveals that she already knows what he thinks. Families usually do know. The therapist's job is to make the knowing speakable.

T3–T5 produce the formulation from the mother's own mouth. Note that the therapist asks only "what makes you say that?" — five words, no interpretation. The hypothesis (the daughter's presence is serving the mother's isolation) is now the mother's own statement,

which is the only form in which it can be worked with. Had the therapist said it, the mother would have had to defend herself against it.

T6 is the **both-and** move: it holds two truths without resolving them. "It helps you and it worries you." This is the linguistic form of circularity, and it is a skill that can be practised: every time you are tempted by "but", try "and".

T7 is the moment of shame, and it must be handled with precision. What the mother fears is that she is being accused of wanting her child ill. T8 does not reassure her ("of course you don't want that") because reassurance would close the opening; it validates the honesty and moves immediately to the child, which distributes the emotional weight and prevents the mother from becoming the identified patient in turn.

T9–T10 bring the child in as an informant about her own behaviour in relation to her mother. T10 is the crucial one: "what happens to your own day when you are getting her water?" It is a question about consequence, addressed to the person with least power, and it invites her to describe her own experience without requiring her to blame her mother. Her answer — that she cannot settle, that she worries, that she cannot face school after a night of listening — completes the loop.

What the therapist avoided, deliberately. She did not ask about the marriage directly in this session. She did not name the father's drinking. She did not offer a diagnosis. She did not reassure the mother that she was a good mother, though she was. Each omission was a decision: the first session's job was to establish that the problem lived between people, and every one of those moves would have pulled it back into one person.

> **DRILL**
> Take turns reading T1–T5 aloud in pairs. The listener must replace T6 with their own "both-and" sentence. Then replace T8 with a sentence that validates without reassuring. Compare. Most attempts either reassure ("you're a good mother") or interpret ("so you see, you need her at home") — both of which close the opening that T7 created.

2.10 Laboratory: the same case, three drawings

The week's assessed practical. Ninety minutes, groups of four, one case per group drawn from the case bank (Appendix to this week).

Stage 1 (20 minutes) — linear account. Each group writes the case as a one-directional chain of at least six arrows, in the form "A → B → C". No loops permitted. This constraint is uncomfortable and instructive: students discover how natural the linear account is, and how much it leaves out.

Stage 2 (25 minutes) — circular account. Redraw as a loop. Rules: every node must be a behaviour or an observable event, not a trait; every arrow must be justifiable from something a family member said; at least one node must be something the therapist could actually change.

Stage 3 (20 minutes) — power overlay. On the same drawing, mark for each member: resources (income, housing, mobility), legitimacy (whose account is believed), and exit options. Then write one sentence stating what the overlay changes about the plan.

Stage 4 (25 minutes) — presenting. Each group presents all three drawings in four minutes. The audience scores on a single criterion: **does the third drawing change the plan?** If the power overlay leaves the intervention identical, the group has decorated rather than analysed.

Marking rubric.

Criterion	Weight	Full marks
Linear account fidelity	15%	Chain is accurate to the referral and contains no smuggled loops
Circular account quality	30%	Nodes behavioural, arrows evidenced, one actionable node identified
Power overlay	25%	Resources, legitimacy and exit named for each member; plan visibly changed
Integration and presentation	20%	Three drawings used together, with the purpose of each stated
Reflexivity	10%	Group can name the drawing they found hardest and why

2.11 Six common errors with circularity

1. **Circularity as absolution.** Using the loop to avoid naming a behaviour that must stop. Fix: pair every circular formulation with an explicit statement of responsibility where responsibility exists.
2. **The endless loop with no entry point.** A drawing with eight nodes and no plausible intervention. Fix: every formulation must nominate the node the therapist will work on first, and why that one.
3. **Loop-washing the history.** "It doesn't matter who started it" is sometimes true and sometimes a way of avoiding a trauma that needs to be named and mourned. Fix: ask the history question, then decide whether to work with it.
4. **Circular questions as interrogation.** Eight questions in a row with no acknowledgement, and a family that closes. Fix: one question, one answer, one acknowledgement; the ratio should feel slow to the therapist.
5. **The hypothesis that cannot lose.** Interpreting every response as confirmation. Fix: write down, before the session, what would count as refutation.
6. **Systems language as a way of sounding clever.** "The system is communicating its homeostatic imperative" is not a sentence that helps anybody. Fix: translate every formulation into language a 14-year-old in the room could follow, and check that you can.

AUDIT

Record one of your own sessions (role-play is fine). Transcribe three minutes. Mark every causal claim you made. Count how many were linear, how many circular, and how many attributed responsibility. If the third number is zero, you have a habit worth breaking.

2.12 Culture, faith and the limits of circularity

Two cautions, both learned the hard way in supervision.

The respectful-withdrawal pattern. In many families, a father's distance is not "coldness" but a culturally scripted division of labour: he is the provider, the mother is the emotional manager of the household, and his non-attendance at a clinic is not a symptom but a role. Reading this pattern as "disengagement" and intervening to increase his emotional involvement can be experienced as an accusation of inadequate masculinity — and it will fail. The better move is to reframe the invitation in terms of his existing role: "I need the person who understands the finances and the school fees, because decisions about Amara's school are partly financial." You are not asking him to become someone else; you are asking him to bring what he already does into the room.

The extended-family triangle. Circular accounts built on the nuclear household routinely miss the grandmother who is the actual decision-maker, the aunt who funds the school, or the uncle whose approval the father needs. When these figures are absent from the drawing, the loop looks like a couple problem and the intervention fails at the point where the real authorisation was required. Ask, always: who else would need to agree for this plan to happen? Then decide whether to invite them, telephone them with consent, or work with the family's account of them.

Faith as an explanation in the system. "This is a spiritual attack" is a causal account, and a serious one. It competes with your circular account, and arguing with it is both rude and ineffective. The systemic move is to treat it as part of the system's explanatory map: who in the family believes it, who does not, what the belief licenses (more prayer, less school), and what the family would accept as evidence either way. Very often the family does not need the therapist to agree; it needs the therapist to take the belief seriously enough to plan around it.

CAUTION

Do not use circularity to soften a disclosure. If a father says "she provoked me" about a physical assault, the correct response is not "so you both escalate". It is to name the act, state that it is not acceptable, and follow the safety protocol. Circular thinking is a tool for understanding, never a substitute for safeguarding.

2.13 Key terms for this week

Term	Definition	Why it matters clinically
Linear causality	A causes B in one direction	Good for history and legal chronology; poor for intervention

Term	Definition	Why it matters clinically
Circular causality	Each element both causes and is caused by the others	The basis of loop formulations and of blame reduction
Punctuation	The way each participant marks a beginning in a sequence, assigning cause	The mechanism by which blame is distributed; changeable through episode work
Feedback (negative)	Process that reduces deviation and restores a set point	Explains stability, including stable misery
Feedback (positive)	Process that amplifies deviation	Explains escalation, crisis and sudden change
Set point	The state a system returns to	Named in the family's own words whenever possible
Delay	Lag between an action and its effect in the system	The reason therapists abandon good interventions too early
Gain	Responsiveness of a system to small deviations	Tells you whether to slow down or speed up
Threshold / hysteresis	The point at which a system flips, and the asymmetry of flipping back	Explains why crises are easier to enter than to leave
Systemic hypothesis	A provisional relational explanation, stated so it can be refuted	Keeps the therapist curious rather than certain
Circular question	A question that elicits difference or relationship between people	The core skill of systemic interviewing
Difference question	Who is most/least affected; who notices first	Maps the distribution of concern
Behavioural-effect question	What one person does when another does X	Builds the sequence in the room
Positive connotation	Describing a symptom as serving the system's cohesion	Powerful, and dangerous if applied to violence
Second-order cybernetics	The observer is part of the observed system	Makes the therapist's own effect part of the data
Constitutive causation	Relations constitute the elements rather than pushing them	The philosophical basis of the loop

2.14 Evidence note: does circularity survive contact with the evidence?

Students are right to ask whether a conceptual scheme this old still earns its place. Three honest answers.

As a description of interaction, circularity is not controversial. Sequential analysis of couple interaction — coding who does what, in what order, and what follows — reliably shows reciprocity: negative affect from one partner raises the probability of negative affect from the other, and the strength of that reciprocity predicts relationship satisfaction. Gottman's cascade models and the demand–withdraw literature (Christensen and colleagues) are, in effect, empirical confirmations that the loop is real. What the literature does not support is the stronger claim that the loop is the cause of the distress,

or that both parties contribute equally. Asymmetry is the norm: demand–withdraw patterns are strongly gendered, with women more often in the demand role and men in the withdraw role, and that asymmetry is not an artefact of observation.

As a therapeutic stance, circularity has modest but real support. Interventions that externalise the problem and reduce mutual blame — reframing, positive connotation, circular questioning used to build shared understanding — are associated with improved alliance and reduced dropout, and the alliance is one of the strongest predictors of outcome. This is not the same as saying that circular formulations cure. It says that a formulation the whole family can accept is a precondition for the work, and circular formulations are better at earning acceptance than accusatory ones.

As a theory of causation, circularity is under-specified. The critique from outside the field is that "circular causality" often means merely "correlation over time", and the critique from inside is that the metaphor smuggles in a homeostatic assumption — that systems prefer the status quo — which is not always true and which can make therapists conservative in the face of change that families are ready for. The most defensible position is the one this week has taught: **circularity is a stance for generating hypotheses and questions, not a causal theory to be tested.** Use it to widen the field and lower blame; do not use it to explain the aetiology of anything.

> **DEBATE**
> "Circular causality is a metaphor that has done more good than harm, and it is time to retire it." Twenty minutes. Note that the strongest argument for retiring it is the violence literature; the strongest against is that no better vocabulary for interaction has been found.

2.15 Self-test

Eight multiple-choice items and three short answers. Answers follow.

1. Which statement best captures negative feedback? (a) A process that amplifies deviation (b) A process that reduces deviation and restores a set point (c) A criticism delivered calmly (d) A system's refusal to change
2. "He goes silent because I shout" and "I shout because he goes silent" are examples of: (a) Linear causality (b) Different punctuations of one sequence (c) Homeostasis (d) Positive connotation
3. Which is a difference question? (a) Why do you fight? (b) What do you do when she cries? (c) Who is most upset by this, and who is least? (d) Do you think he is depressed?
4. A couple escalate quickly and the session feels unmanageable. In systems terms the system has: (a) High gain (b) Low gain (c) High delay (d) Strong hysteresis
5. The strongest reason to give an intervention three sessions before judging it is: (a) Families are resistant (b) Delay in feedback loops (c) Therapist fatigue (d) Ethical guidelines
6. Which formulation error does "you are both keeping the cycle going" most clearly risk when there is violence? (a) Over-attributing responsibility (b) Absolving responsibility (c) Confusing content and relationship (d) Ignoring delay

7. A hypothesis that cannot be refuted is best described as: (a) Robust (b) Systemic (c) A belief (d) A difference question
8. Positive connotation should not be used when: (a) The family is angry (b) There is violence or abuse (c) The therapist is unsure (d) The symptom is mild

Answers. 1 b · 2 b · 3 c · 4 a · 5 b · 6 b · 7 c · 8 b.

Short answers (150 words each).

Explain the difference between a linear and a circular formulation, using one family. A strong answer names the direction of the arrows, states that the linear account is not false but incomplete, gives a specific sequence, and shows what each formulation licenses clinically — including that the linear account is the one a court or a school will usually want.

What does the power overlay add to a circular formulation? A strong answer names resources, legitimacy and exit options; explains that circularity describes interaction while power explains whose interaction counts; and gives an example in which the overlay changes the intervention (for instance, from "reduce mutual escalation" to "name the violence, safety-plan, and refer").

Why can a good hypothesis make a therapist worse? A strong answer describes confirmatory questioning, the loss of curiosity, the family's experience of being interpreted, and the discipline of writing down a refutation condition before the session.

2.16 Reflective task

Think of a recurring difficulty in your own family. Write two paragraphs. In the first, punctuate it the way you usually do — that is, with the other person's behaviour as the beginning. In the second, punctuate it from the other person's position, with your behaviour as the beginning. Do not try to be fair; try to be accurate about what each punctuation leaves out.

Then answer, in three sentences: what did you have to believe about yourself to write the second paragraph, and what did you have to give up? Most students find the answer uncomfortable, and that discomfort is the beginning of the capacity to hold a loop without needing to be innocent in it.

2.17 Readings for this week

Read the first two before the lecture.

- **Watzlawick, Beavin & Jackson (1967)**, Pragmatics of Human Communication, chapter 2 — punctuation, in the original. Notice how much of the argument is philosophical rather than empirical.
- **Selvini Palazzoli, Boscolo, Cecchin & Prata (1980)**, "Hypothesizing–circularity–neutrality: three guidelines for the conductor of the session", Family Process. The canonical statement of Milan technique.
- **Bateson (1972)**, Steps to an Ecology of Mind, part III. The cybernetic essays, which are better written than most of what followed.

- **Hoffman (1981)**, Foundations of Family Therapy, chapters 1–4. The best history of the shift from linear to circular thinking.
- **Goldner (1985)**, "Feminism and family therapy", Family Process, and **Hare-Mustin (1978)**, "A feminist approach to family therapy", Journal of Marital and Family Therapy. The critique that circularity without power is not neutral.
- **Christensen & Heavey (1990)** and the later demand–withdraw literature. Read one empirical paper on reciprocity and note what it does and does not establish.

Next: Week 3 — A short history of the field

Week 3 — A short history of the field

3.1 The lecture in ninety minutes

Why does a clinician need history? Three reasons, and they are not decorative. First, models are answers to questions, and you cannot evaluate an answer without the question. Second, the field's current fashions are usually old arguments in new clothes, and a clinician who knows the argument is harder to sell a rebranding. Third, your own professional identity is built from this material: what you call yourself, what you think you are doing, and what you refuse to do all come from a seventy-year conversation.

The lecture is a walk through five waves, with a hard question attached to each.

Minutes	Segment	What the lecturer does	What students do
0–10	Prehistory	The child guidance movement, marriage counselling, social casework	Note which problems each could and could not solve
10–30	Wave 1: communication	Palo Alto, Bateson, Jackson, Haley, Watzlawick	Timeline: place five key texts
30–45	Wave 2: structure and generations	Minuchin, Haley, Bowen, Satir	Draw the same family as each would see it
45–60	Wave 3: meaning	Milan, systemic therapy, positive connotation, circular questioning	Identify what Milan added and what it cost
60–72	Wave 4: solutions and stories	de Shazer, White, Epston, Andersen	Compare two session transcripts
72–85	Wave 5: evidence and integration	Common factors, attachment, neuroscience, feedback-informed work	Argue for what the sixth wave will be
85–90	Set the essay	The comparative assignment (3.14)	Choose two models to compare

3.2 Prehistory: three streams before "family therapy"

Nobody invented family therapy in a single place. Three professional streams were converging by 1950, each with its own methods and its own blind spots.

Child guidance. From the 1920s, clinics in the United States and Britain treated children referred for behavioural and emotional problems. The standard team was a psychiatrist, a psychologist and a social worker: the psychiatrist saw the child, the social worker saw the mother. Fathers were largely absent from the literature, and the mother was usually the object of investigation — a framing that did enormous damage and whose echoes are still audible in referrals today ("mother is over-involved"). The practical legacy is the multi-disciplinary team, which survives in child and adolescent mental health services.

Marriage counselling. From the 1930s, and especially after the Second World War, counsellors began seeing couples together — often in religious or voluntary settings, often with an explicitly moral vocabulary. The American Association of Marriage Counsellors was founded in 1942. Its legacy is the couple as a legitimate clinical unit and, less happily, a tendency to treat marital distress as a communication problem to be instructed rather than a system to be understood.

Social casework. Caseworkers had always worked with families, but as the environment of an individual client rather than as a system with its own properties. The legacy is attention to context — housing, income, kin, migration — that purely psychological models lack, and which this library's cultural chapters depend on.

What the three streams lacked. A theory of interaction. Each could describe a person in a family; none could describe the family as a thing with a structure. That arrived from an unexpected direction: engineering and biology.

3.3 Wave 1: communication (1952–1970)

The founding texts are not clinical. They are cybernetic and anthropological, and that origin still shapes how the field thinks.

Bateson's project. Gregory Bateson — anthropologist, cyberneticist, and a man whose influence is out of all proportion to the number of patients he treated — assembled a research group at Palo Alto from 1952 with Jay Haley, John Weakland and, from 1954, Don Jackson. They studied communication in families with a member diagnosed with schizophrenia, and produced the double-bind paper in 1956. Bateson's wider project was a theory of mind as a property of systems rather than brains: "the difference which makes a difference", information as a pattern in a circuit.

Jackson and homeostasis. Don Jackson, a psychiatrist, founded the Mental Research Institute (MRI) in 1959 and, with Ackerman, the journal Family Process in 1962. His contribution was the application of homeostasis to families: a family is a rule-governed system that maintains itself against change, and symptomatic behaviour can be part of that maintenance. He also introduced **family homeostasis** as a clinical observation: when one member improves, another may worsen, because the system's set point has not changed.

Haley and strategy. Jay Haley's Strategies of Psychotherapy (1963) and Problem-Solving Therapy (1976) treated symptoms as tactics in a power struggle, and therapy as a contest of influence to be won by the therapist's directives. Out of this came **strategic therapy**: prescribing the symptom, ordeals, paradoxical instructions, and a therapist who takes

responsibility for change. Haley's later collaboration with Cloe Madanes produced a body of technique that is unfashionable and still effective in the right hands.

Watzlawick and the axioms. Pragmatics of Human Communication (1967) gave the field a vocabulary: one cannot not communicate; content and relationship levels; punctuation; digital and analogic codes; symmetrical and complementary relationships. Two of these are now so embedded in clinical language that students use them without knowing their source, which is exactly what a foundational vocabulary looks like.

What wave 1 got right. The unit is the sequence. Communication is not a skill laid on top of a relationship; it is the relationship. Change the sequence and the symptoms move.

What wave 1 got wrong. It was often manipulative (therapists withholding information, using paradox on unconsenting families), it was blind to power and gender, and its central aetiological claim about schizophrenia was false. Students should be able to say all three without either dismissing the wave or defending it.

3.4 Wave 2: structure and generations (1965–1980)

Wave 2 made the field clinical. It brought families into rooms, built training programmes, and produced the models still most widely taught.

Minuchin and structure. Salvador Minuchin, trained as a paediatrician and psychoanalyst, worked with delinquent boys at the Wiltwyck School and then led the Philadelphia Child Guidance Clinic from 1965. His observation was that these families were not deficient in insight or motivation; they were **organised** in ways that made the child's symptom functional — a weak parental subsystem, a child in coalition with one parent against the other, boundaries too diffuse or too rigid. Families and Family Therapy (1974) remains the clearest book in the field. His techniques — joining, enactment, unbalancing, restructuring, mapping — are the backbone of MFT 706.

Haley in Philadelphia. Haley joined Minuchin in 1967, and the exchange between structure and strategy produced much of what is now standard: the therapist as an active organiser of the session, the deliberate use of directives, the assumption that change in behaviour precedes change in understanding.

Bowen and the generations. Murray Bowen, at the Menninger Clinic and later Georgetown, built the most elaborate theory in the field: **differentiation of self** (the capacity to stay emotionally connected while thinking for oneself), **triangles** (the three-person unit as the molecule of emotional systems), **multigenerational transmission** (patterns passed down and intensified across generations), **family projection** (a child recruited to carry the family's undifferentiation), **emotional cutoff**, and **societal regression**. Bowen's therapy was explicitly about the therapist's own family of origin: trainees were required to work on their own genograms and to re-enter relationships with their families of origin as the core of their training. That requirement is why this library asks you to do a reflective task every week.

Satir and the person. Virginia Satir brought warmth, communication training, family sculpture and an explicitly humanistic value system. Her categories — placator, blamer, computer, distractor, leveller — are crude and useful: students recognise them instantly,

and so do families. She also insisted, against the cybernetic mainstream, that the therapist's own personhood is the instrument, a claim that the common-factors literature later supported with less charm.

The experiential wing. Carl Whitaker's symbolic-experiential therapy — deliberately unsettling, co-therapy with a live team, the therapist's own fantasies used in the room — represents a road the field mostly did not take, and its influence survives in the use of self and in the practice of working with the therapist's own reactions in the moment.

> **PRACTICAL**
> Take the Okonkwo family. Write four sentences describing the same session as Minuchin, Bowen, Satir and Whitaker would each have conducted it. Where do they differ: in the seating, the first question, the target of change, or the theory of what a symptom is?

3.5 Wave 3: meaning (1975–1990)

The Milan group — Selvini Palazzoli, Boscolo, Cecchin and Prata — began as strategic therapists and became something else. Their Paradox and Counterparadox (1978) described a team working behind a one-way mirror, long intervals between sessions, and interventions delivered as letters: rituals, positive connotation, and the **prescription of the symptom**. The style was hierarchical, elegant and, in retrospect, ethically awkward.

By the early 1980s the group had split, and the second phase — associated especially with Cecchin — turned from intervention to **meaning**. The key concepts: **hypothesising** (a provisional explanation, held lightly and revised), **circularity** (the interviewer's discipline of asking about differences and relationships), **neutrality** (curiosity about all positions rather than indifference), and **circular questioning** as the primary instrument. The therapist's job was less to change the system than to introduce information that the system could not have generated itself.

Second-order cybernetics entered here, through the work of Heinz von Foerster and the writing of Lynn Hoffman ("Beyond power and control", 1985). The observer is part of the observed system; there is no Archimedean point; therapy is a conversation in which the therapist's own descriptions are part of what is described. This is intellectually attractive and clinically dangerous, because a therapist who is only curious can leave a violent household undisturbed. The corrective came from the outside, in wave 5.

The reflecting team. Tom Andersen, in Tromsø, Norway, developed the reflecting team (1985–87): the team observes and then discusses in front of the family, with the family listening, in a tone of tentative curiosity. The move distributes expertise and gives the family the experience of being thought about rather than judged. It is one of the few techniques of this period that has survived intact and is used across models.

3.6 Wave 4: solutions and stories (1980–2000)

Two movements, both impatient with pathology, both popular with trainees because they feel respectful, and both vulnerable to the criticism that respect can shade into avoidance.

Solution-focused brief therapy. Steve de Shazer, Insoo Kim Berg and colleagues at the Milwaukee Brief Family Therapy Center built an approach around the question "what would be different if the problem were solved?" — the **miracle question** — plus **scaling**, **exceptions** (times the problem did not happen), and **coping questions**. The stance is minimal-intervention, client-as-expert, and oriented to the next small step. The strength: engagement, brevity, respect. The weakness: when there is trauma, violence or serious mental illness, a focus on solutions can leave the worst of the situation unaddressed, and the therapist may not notice, because the conversation is pleasant.

Narrative therapy. Michael White and David Epston, in Adelaide and Auckland, worked from the premise that people organise experience through stories, and that problems are maintained by **dominant stories** that narrow what a person can be. The techniques: **externalisation** ("the problem is the problem, the person is not the problem"), **unique outcomes** (moments that contradict the dominant story), **re-authoring**, **definitional ceremonies**, and the use of letters and documents. The political commitment is explicit: narrative therapy is designed to notice and resist the power of diagnosis, institutions and cultural norms — including, in White's later work, the norms that shape gender and family life.

Collaborative and dialogic practice. Harlene Anderson and Harry Goolishian's collaborative language systems approach, and the open-dialogue work of Jaakko Seikkula in Finnish Western Lapland, pushed further: therapy as a conversation among many voices, the therapist as a participant in a dialogue rather than an agent of change. Open dialogue's outcomes with first-episode psychosis have been widely discussed and are methodologically contested; students should read the primary papers rather than the summaries, which are usually more enthusiastic than the data.

> **DEBATE**
> "Solution-focused and narrative therapy are the most ethical models in the field, and the least adequate for serious risk." Twenty minutes. Both halves of the sentence need defending.

3.7 Wave 5: evidence, attachment and integration (1990–present)

Contemporary practice is not a single wave but a convergence, and students should be able to name its parts.

The evidence movement. Manualised treatments, randomised trials, meta-analysis, and the rise of evidence-based practice as a policy requirement. Its achievements are real: couple therapy for relationship distress, behavioural parent training, family-based treatment for anorexia, multidimensional family therapy for adolescent substance use, and systemic work in paediatric chronic illness all have credible support. Its costs are also real: manualisation can strip the flexibility that made systemic work effective; trials under-represent the families who actually attend public clinics; and the hierarchy of evidence privileges questions about average effects over questions about mechanism and meaning.

The common-factors turn. Research on the alliance, on therapist effects and on client factors demonstrated that a large share of outcome variance is not attributable to the model. This did not make models irrelevant; it made the fit between model, therapist and family the central question. Feedback-informed treatment — the routine use of session-by-session outcome and alliance measures — is the practical descendant, and it is now a standard of good practice rather than an innovation.

Attachment. Emotionally focused therapy (Sue Johnson, Les Greenberg) rebuilt couple therapy on attachment theory and emotion science. It is the most influential couple model of the last thirty years, and its evidence base — including several randomised trials and meta-analytic support — is the strongest of any couple approach. Attachment thinking also reorganised work with children, fostering and adoption (see MFT 711).

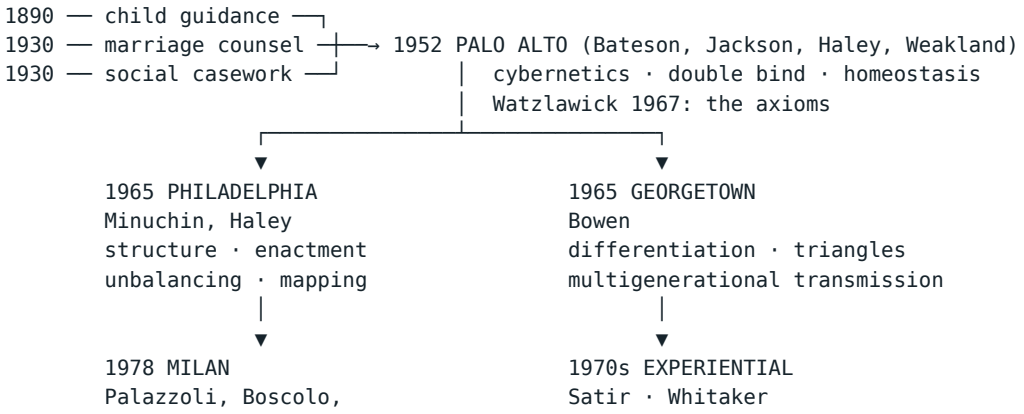
Neuroscience. Findings on the social brain, stress physiology, co-regulation and memory have enriched the field's language and some of its techniques (see MFT 726). The danger is **neuro-pseudo-profundity**: using brain vocabulary as though it explained what it merely redescribes. Polyvagal theory, in particular, is clinically generative and scientifically contested; a professional should be able to use its metaphors while saying honestly that the mechanism is not settled.

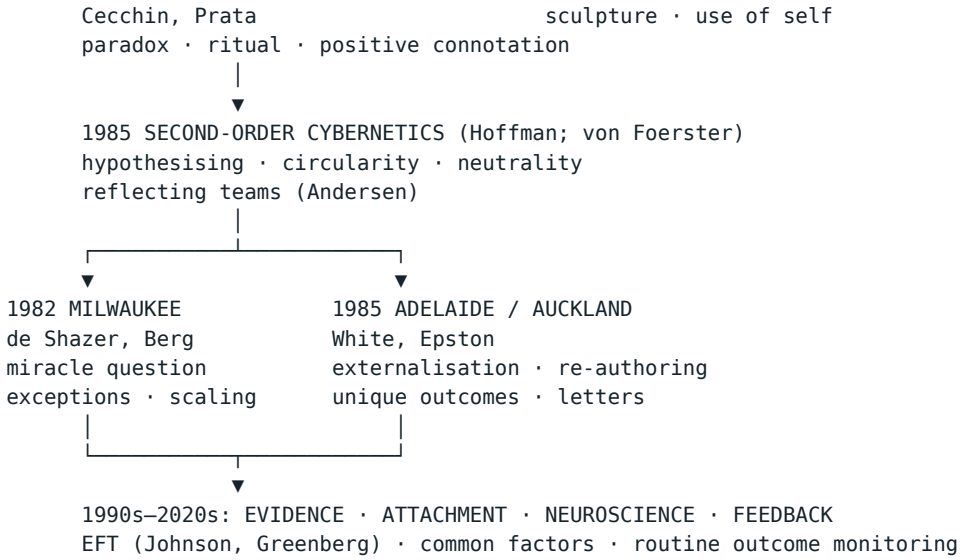
Integration and the common structure. Most practitioners now describe themselves as integrative. The substantive question is not whether to integrate but how: by theory (a superordinate framework), by technique (borrowing tools), by sequence (matching the model to the phase of work), or by feedback (letting outcome data choose). MFT 725 takes this up properly; here it is enough to note that "integrative" is a description of a problem, not a solution.

> **TASK**
> Write 300 words predicting the sixth wave. Defend it with two pieces of evidence from the last five years and one prediction that could be shown to be wrong within a decade. Keep it; you will reread it in Week 14.

3.8 The family tree as a diagram

The history is easier to hold as a picture than as a list. Draw it once, by hand, and you will not need to revise it.





Read the diagram three ways. **Vertically**, as descent: Milan comes out of Palo Alto, solution-focused and narrative come out of Milan's turn to meaning. **Horizontally**, as disagreement: Philadelphia and Georgetown were contemporaries answering the same question differently, and their disagreement about whether the target is structure or differentiation is still unresolved. **Diagonally**, as return: the contemporary interest in attachment is a return to wave 1's question about emotional bonds, with better instruments.

What the diagram leaves out, and why it matters. The feminist critique (Hare-Mustin, Goldner, Walters, Bograd, and later intersectional writers) is drawn as an arrow into the whole picture rather than a branch: it did not produce a school but it changed every school's self-understanding, by insisting that power, gender and violence are not background variables. The same is true of the cultural critique, which this library treats as constitutive rather than supplementary (MFT 708).

3.9 What each wave still gives you

Students often ask, reasonably, which model to learn. The honest answer is that each wave contributes something you will use whatever you call yourself, and that the contributions are not equally large.

Wave	Permanent contribution	What to leave behind
Communication	Sequence, punctuation, feedback vocabulary, the idea that communication is the relationship	Manipulation; treating paradox as a default; the double-bind aetiology
Structure and generations	Enactment, joining, mapping, subsystem and boundary language, the multigenerational lens, work on the therapist's own family	Rigid normative assumptions about "healthy" family form
Meaning	Hypothesising, circular questioning, reflecting teams, curiosity as a discipline	Neutrality as an excuse for inaction in the face of danger

Wave	Permanent contribution	What to leave behind
Solutions and stories	Engagement, brevity, externalisation, respect for the family's own language and values	Avoidance of trauma, risk and diagnosis dressed as respect
Evidence and integration	Outcome measurement, attachment science, feedback-informed practice, training in what demonstrably helps	Manual-worship; neuro-vocabulary substituting for mechanism

The test of a professional. Can you say, for a specific family, why you chose a particular stance and what you would have done differently if you had chosen another? The therapist who cannot answer that question is not eclectic; they are unskilled and lucky.

3.10 The Adeyemi family seen through five lenses

The same family, five ways. This exercise is the heart of the week: it demonstrates that the models are not competing truths but different instruments, each of which reveals something the others hide.

Communication lens (wave 1). The sequence: father criticises → mother defends Amara → father withdraws → Amara refuses school → mother appeals to father → father criticises. Punctuation: father says "she is out of control because you indulge her"; mother says "he is never here and then he interferes". The intervention would be to slow the sequence, mark the punctuation, and change one link — for example, agreeing that criticism happens only in a scheduled conversation. What this lens sees: the mechanics of escalation. What it misses: the father's grief about his job, which is the fuel.

Structural lens (wave 2). The parental subsystem is weak; Amara is in a coalition with her mother against her father; the boundary between mother and daughter is diffuse. The intervention: strengthen the parental subsystem by giving the parents a joint task, move Amara out of the executive position, and re-establish the sibling subsystem by giving the brother a role that is not "the easy one". What this lens sees: hierarchy and coalition, and it produces action immediately. What it misses: the meaning of the father's drinking and the mother's depression, which structure alone treats as noise.

Multigenerational lens (Bowen). The father's own father was a proud man who lost everything in a business failure and drank; the father's withdrawal is a repetition he has never named. The mother is the child who managed her own mother's depression and has recruited Amara to the same role — family projection in progress. The intervention: a genogram across three generations, work on the father's relationship with his own father, and coaching the mother to differentiate rather than to manage. What this lens sees: the timeline that explains why this family, now. What it misses: the immediate sequence, and the risk that a multigenerational story becomes an excuse ("it was passed down to us").

Meaning lens (wave 3). What does the family believe is happening? Mother: "I am failing as a mother." Father: "I am no longer the man of this house." Amara: "If I leave, something will happen." Brother: "Nobody notices me." The intervention: circular questions that make these beliefs audible to one another; a reframe that the family is protecting each other rather than failing; a ritual — a weekly family conversation with a fixed structure — that lets new meanings be enacted. What this lens sees: the moral world

of the family and its capacity for loyalty. What it misses: the practicalities of a household in financial strain.

Solution-focused lens (wave 4). Exceptions: what happens on the days Amara goes to school? (Her mother's sister visited; the father was at home in the morning.) Scaling: where are you today, 0 to 10, on "this family coping"? What would one point higher look like this week? The intervention: build on the exceptions, deliberately, one small step at a time. What this lens sees: competence, and it engages a family exhausted by being a problem. What it misses: the depression and the drinking, which are not solved by scaling.

The point of the exercise. A formulation is a choice of lens for a purpose, and the competent clinician uses at least two lenses and says which they are using. The incompetent clinician uses one lens, calls it "the evidence-based approach", and cannot explain what it hides.

> **PRACTICAL**
> In groups of five, each person takes one lens and prepares a five-minute opening for the family. Present in role. The observers score each opening on two criteria: does it fit the family's own language, and does it make the next step obvious?

3.10a Four primary sources, read closely

History is learned from secondary summaries at the student's peril. Below are four short extracts, each with what to notice. You do not need to agree with any of them; you need to be able to say what they claim and what they assume.

Bateson, Jackson, Haley and Weakland (1956), on the double bind. The authors describe a mother who, when her child approaches, stiffens; when the child withdraws, she asks why he does not love her. The child cannot win and cannot comment on the game. What to notice: the paper is hedged much more carefully than its reputation suggests — the authors call it a hypothesis and explicitly disclaim a simple causal claim; and the language of "victim" is used without any account of what the mother herself is experiencing. That absence is the seed of the feminist critique, twenty years early.

Watzlawick, Beavin and Jackson (1967), on punctuation. "The nature of a relationship is contingent upon the punctuation of the communicational sequences between the communicants." What to notice: this is a claim about description, not about causation. The authors do not say both parties are equally responsible; they say each behaves as though the other started it. Students who muddle those two claims produce circularity without accountability, which is the error discussed in Week 2.

Minuchin (1974), on structure. "The therapist joins the family in a position of leadership and then uses himself to change the organisation." What to notice: the therapist is inside, and directive. The sentence is unimaginable in the Milan writing that followed, and it is the ancestor of every modern discussion of the therapist's use of self.

White (1989), on externalisation. "The problem is the problem; the person is not the problem." What to notice: the sentence's power is grammatical. It separates a person from

a description, which changes what the family can do; and its weakness is that some problems are also acts — violence is not merely a story, and a person who commits it is not only a narrator.

3.11 Annotated transcript: history in one sentence

Students often experience the history as inert because it is taught as a list of names. It comes alive when you see a clinician choose a tradition in a single sentence. Four openings, all defensible, all different.

> **OPENING A (STRUCTURAL):**
> "Before we talk about Amara, I would like to see how the two of you decide something together. Can you choose something small — the next school letter, say — and decide it now, in front of me?"

What this does. It creates the parental subsystem by asking it to act, and it gives the therapist live data rather than reported data. It comes straight out of Minuchin's enactment. What it costs. It is directive, and a family that feels managed will resist it; it presumes the parents can act together at all.

> **OPENING B (BOWENIAN):**
> "I want to understand where this pattern comes from. Could you tell me about your own parents' marriage — what happened in their house when money was short?"

What this does. It places the current difficulty in a multigenerational frame and begins the process of differentiation by asking an adult to think about their family rather than react within it. What it costs. It can feel like a history lesson when the family wants relief, and it can deflect from immediate risk.

> **OPENING C (MILAN):**
> "I am going to ask some unusual questions, and I want each of you to answer for someone else. Amara, who in this family is most worried about your mother? And who is least worried?"

What this does. It builds a map of the system's concern and immediately distributes the problem across relationships. What it costs. It can feel like a parlour game, particularly with a family in acute distress, and it can produce abstract answers that the therapist then over-interprets.

> **OPENING D (SOLUTION-FOCUSED):**
> "Tell me about a day in the last month when things went better than usual — even slightly. What was different about that morning?"

What this does. It starts from competence and gives the family an experience of itself as capable, which is powerful with a demoralised household. What it costs. If the honest answer is "there hasn't been one", the therapist is left holding an approach the family has

just refuted; a skilled practitioner will have a bridge ready ("then tell me how you have kept going").

The lesson. Each opening is a hypothesis about what will help, expressed as a first move. Your training should leave you able to make any of the four deliberately, and able to explain afterwards why you chose the one you chose. That capacity — not loyalty to a school — is what "integrative" should mean.

> **DRILL**
> Deliver all four openings to the same peer, in role as the mother. Ask which one made her want to come back, and which one made her want to leave. The answers will surprise you and will differ by person, which is the point.

3.11a How the field's arguments became clinical habits

The history is not over; its disagreements are embedded in the language clinicians use, usually without attribution. Five examples.

"Let's not get into the past" comes from the strategic and solution-focused waves, which treated history as a distraction from the loop. It is right about the futility of archaeology and wrong when the past contains unmourned loss or untreated trauma.

"Everyone in the family is doing their best" comes from Satir and the humanistic wing. It is a useful corrective to pathologising and a dangerous substitute for accountability.

"What would it look like if the problem were solved?" comes from Milwaukee. It is the single most portable question in the field and it will fail with a family for whom the problem is a death.

"That's a boundary issue" comes from Minuchin, filtered through thirty years of training. It is often accurate and almost always unusable as a sentence uttered in the room.

"The system is resisting" comes from the cybernetic wave and is the field's most damaging inheritance. It converts the therapist's failure into the family's pathology. The corrective is a sentence this library repeats: if nothing is changing, check the formulation, the dose, the goal and the fit before you check the family's motivation.

> **AUDIT**
> List five sentences you habitually use in clinical conversation. For each, identify which wave it comes from and what it assumes. Then mark the ones you would be unable to defend if challenged by a colleague, a supervisor or a family member.

3.12 Six errors in using history

1. **The name-drop.** Citing Bateson to a family. Fix: history is for you, not for them; translate every idea into the family's language before it leaves your mouth.

2. **Nostalgia.** Treating the 1970s as a golden age. Fix: name what those clinicians did that would now be unethical, and say why.
3. **Fashion as evidence.** Adopting a model because it is current or because a training was convenient. Fix: ask what evidence supports it for this problem, and what it costs.
4. **Model loyalty as identity.** "I am a structural therapist" as a personality claim. Fix: describe what you do, when, and why; let others attach a label if they need one.
5. **The single-story training.** Learning one model deeply and calling it integration. Fix: the comparative assignment exists for this reason; do it honestly.
6. **Ignoring the critiques.** Teaching the canon without the feminist, anti-racist and survivor critiques. Fix: they are not add-ons; they are the reason the canon changed.

3.12a A supervision case: what happens when the model fails

A trainee presented this in supervision. She had been working with a family of four for six sessions using a structural approach — joining, mapping, enacting, unbalancing — and nothing had shifted. The parents performed the joint tasks in the room and abandoned them at home. The children were polite and blank. The trainee's formulation, reviewed in supervision, was accurate but incomplete: she had described the family's organisation and had not asked what the organisation was for.

Two questions changed the case.

"What does this family believe would happen if they did the task?" The answer, discovered through circular questions, was that both parents believed that acting together would expose the marriage as a pretence. The father's family had a saying: "a house that discusses its problems is a house with no roof." The mother had been raised to keep the peace at any price, and had watched her own mother absorb her father's rage for thirty years. The structural task was, from inside their world, a request to demolish the house.

"What has this family survived together?" A fire, a business collapse, a stillbirth, and a period of separation the children knew nothing about. This is a family with a history of endurance and a rule that endurance is done silently.

What the trainee did in the next session. She abandoned the enactment task for the moment and used a different instrument: she asked the parents, in front of the children, to describe one thing they were proud of having got through together. It took four minutes and produced more contact between them than six sessions of structure. She then reframed the joint parental task in the family's own terms — not "decide together" but "as a family that has survived worse, decide how to handle this one".

The lesson for this week. Models are instruments, and the skill is diagnostic: when an instrument is not working, the question is not "how do I do the technique better?" but "what does the family's world make this technique mean?" That question is historical in its logic — it asks which tradition of family life the family itself belongs to, and which of the field's available languages can reach them. A therapist who has only one model has only one chance of finding a language the family can hear.

3.13 Culture, faith and the Nigerian lineage

The history above is mostly North American and European, and a student in Ibadan should ask what it has to do with them. Two answers.

First, the critiques from the global South are part of the field's history, not a local appendix. The assumption that the nuclear household is the unit, that individuation is the goal, and that the therapist is a neutral observer have all been contested from African, Asian and Latin American contexts for decades. The Nigerian literature — in counselling, psychology, social work and pastoral care — has its own lineage: community mental health work in the 1970s and 1980s, the integration of traditional healers into referral pathways, pastoral counselling in the churches and alfas and imams in the mosques, and a strong tradition of family-life education. Knowing that lineage is not decoration: it is what allows you to place imported models rather than being placed by them.

Second, the extended family is a theoretical asset, not a complication. Western family therapy spent thirty years discovering that the household is not the system — through work on multigenerational process, on non-resident fathers, on kinship care. A clinician trained in a context where grandmothers, aunts, uncles and cousins routinely co-parent starts with that insight rather than arriving at it. The task is to make it explicit and teachable, not to apologise for it.

A caution. Cultural specificity can become a way of exempting families from scrutiny. "In our culture, discipline means beating" is a claim that requires examination, not deference — the evidence on corporal punishment is clear, and the child's safety is not a Western import. The discipline is to take the family's frame seriously and to hold the professional's obligations, including the legal ones (see MFT 724).

> **REFLECT**
> Which of the five waves most resembles how your own family handles difficulty? Which one most resembles how you were taught to handle it professionally? Write 250 words on the gap between them.

3.13a The Nigerian and African lineage, in more detail

A student who learns only the North American canon will arrive at a professional identity that is borrowed. The local lineage is substantial and should be known.

Community psychiatry and the extension of care, 1960s–1980s. The Aro Mental Hospital in Abeokuta, and its community-based programme from the early 1960s under T. Adeoye Lambo, is a landmark in world psychiatry: it replaced custodial care with village-based care, involved families and traditional healers, and demonstrated outcomes that were, for their time, remarkable. Family involvement was not an added technique; it was the model. Any honest history of systemic practice has to include it.

Traditional and faith-based healing as part of the referral system. Herbalists, babalawos, pastors, alfas and imams are, for most Nigerian families, the first port of call and sometimes the only one. The professional task is not to compete but to understand, coordinate and — where a practice is dangerous — to say so clearly while keeping the

family engaged. Research on collaboration between traditional healers and formal services has a long history in Nigeria and West Africa, and the practical lessons are consistent: respect, clarity about what each can offer, and an explicit safety floor.

Family life education and pastoral counselling. Churches and mosques run premarital counselling, marriage enrichment, and considerable informal couple and family work. Many of the referrals you will receive come through these channels, and many of the families you see will have had a pastoral conversation before they had a clinical one. Knowing what those conversations contain — and their limits — makes you a better collaborator and a less anxious professional.

The academic lineage. Departments of psychology, sociology, guidance and counselling, and social work in Nigerian universities have produced a substantial literature on marriage, family structure, child-rearing, migration and mental health. Students writing dissertations (MFT 721, MFT 770) should search it deliberately: the international databases are not neutral archives, and a literature review that cites only Northern journals will have missed the studies with the most relevant samples.

What to take from this. The relational frame is not an import that must be adapted to local reality; it is an insight that local practice arrived at independently, with different vocabulary and different institutional forms. Your task is to learn both lineages and to be able to say, for any particular technique, whether it travels, what it needs to travel, and what it might destroy on arrival.

3.14 The comparative essay: how to write it

Half of the marks for this course come from a comparative essay of 2,000 words on two models applied to one case. Students lose marks in predictable ways, and the essay is easier than it looks if you follow the structure.

The brief. Choose two models from different waves — for example, structural (wave 2) and narrative (wave 4), or Milan systemic (wave 3) and emotionally focused (wave 5). Choose one family from the case bank. Write an essay with the following sections, in this order.

1. **The presenting pattern** (250 words). The family as they arrive: who is worried, who is present, what has been tried, what the referral says. No theory yet. This section establishes that you can describe before you interpret — a skill examiners find conspicuously rare.
2. **Model one: how it sees** (450 words). The model's assumptions: what a symptom is, where pathology lives, what counts as the unit, what counts as change. Then the formulation in that model's terms, in its vocabulary, with the specific evidence from the case that supports it.
3. **Model one: what it would do** (250 words). Two or three concrete moves, in sequence, with the reasoning. Not "use enactment"; rather, "ask the parents to decide the school letter in front of Amara, because the parental subsystem is the target and doing it live gives me better data than asking about it".

4. **Model two: how it sees** (450 words). As above. Resist the temptation to make model two a foil; a comparison in which one model is obviously superior is a failed comparison.
5. **Model two: what it would do** (250 words). As above.
6. **The comparison** (250 words). Where do the two formulations conflict? Where do they merely differ in emphasis? What does each model see that the other cannot? Which would you choose for this family, and on what grounds — evidence, fit, the family's preferences, your own competence, or the setting's constraints? The grounds must be explicit.
7. **Conclusion** (100 words). What you have learned about the relationship between theory and practice.

The six ways students lose marks. Describing models without applying them to the case; applying both models to different aspects of the case so no comparison occurs; declaring one model "more holistic" without evidence; using the models' jargon without translating it; ignoring power, culture and risk; and failing to state a reasoned preference.

Model paragraph, for calibration. Here is a body paragraph at distinction level.

> Structural family therapy locates the problem in the organisation of the family rather than in the individual. Minuchin's claim is that symptomatic children are frequently occupying a position in the hierarchy that belongs to adults — in coalition with one parent against the other, or parentified by an absent adult. This is visible in the Adeyemi family in three places: Amara sits beside her mother and answers questions addressed to her; she describes managing her mother's low mood; and her father, when he attends, is treated by both as a visitor whose opinion arrives from outside the household. The structural formulation is therefore that the parental subsystem is not functioning as a subsystem, and that Amara's school refusal is a stabilising move within that structure. What this formulation gains is a target that can be acted on in the room: the therapist can create the parental subsystem by giving the parents a joint task and observing them attempt it. What it risks losing is the meaning of the father's absence to the father — his own redundancy, his own father's drinking — which structural language can describe as "distance" but cannot explain.

Note what the paragraph does: it names the model's claim, applies it to specific observable evidence, states what the formulation buys and what it costs. That last sentence is what separates a distinction from a competent pass.

3.15 Timeline for revision

Twenty dates, in the order a student should be able to produce them. The examination sometimes asks for a timeline, and always rewards precision about which decade a development belongs to.

Year	Event	Why it matters
1942	American Association of Marriage Counsellors founded	The couple as a clinical unit, before "family therapy" existed

Year	Event	Why it matters
1952	Bateson's group begins work at Palo Alto	Cybernetics enters the study of families
1956	"Toward a theory of schizophrenia" published	The double bind; the field's founding controversy
1959	Mental Research Institute founded (Jackson)	An institutional base for communication research
1960	Ackerman Family Institute, New York	Clinical training in family therapy begins
1962	Family Process founded (Ackerman and Jackson)	The field acquires a journal and a canon
1963	Haley, Strategies of Psychotherapy	Strategic therapy formalised
1965	Minuchin leads the Philadelphia Child Guidance Clinic	Structural family therapy develops
1966	Bowen, "The use of family theory in clinical practice"	Differentiation and triangles published
1967	Watzlawick, Beavin and Jackson, Pragmatics	The axioms; the field's vocabulary fixed
1972	Bateson, Steps to an Ecology of Mind	The cybernetic essays collected
1974	Minuchin, Families and Family Therapy	The clearest clinical text in the field
1978	Selvini Palazzoli et al., Paradox and Counterparadox	Milan systemic therapy; the team behind the mirror
1980	"Hypothesizing–circularity–neutrality" published	The technique of circular questioning formalised
1982	Milwaukee Brief Family Therapy Center founded	Solution-focused work begins
1985	Hoffman, "Beyond power and control"	Second-order cybernetics enters clinical writing
1985–87	Andersen's reflecting team papers	The team discusses in front of the family
1990	White and Epston, Narrative Means to Therapeutic Ends	Narrative therapy consolidated
1990s	EFT trials begin to appear (Johnson, Greenberg)	Attachment-based couple therapy acquires evidence
2000s–	Feedback-informed treatment; routine outcome monitoring	The model matters less than the fit and the feedback

3.16 Self-test

Multiple choice, then short answers.

1. The double-bind hypothesis was developed by: (a) Minuchin and Haley (b) Bateson, Jackson, Haley and Weakland (c) Bowen and Kerr (d) White and Epston
2. "The problem is the problem; the person is not the problem" is a principle of: (a) Structural therapy (b) Strategic therapy (c) Narrative therapy (d) Bowenian therapy
3. Which model is most associated with enactment and unbalancing? (a) Milan systemic (b) Structural (c) Solution-focused (d) Collaborative

4. Positive connotation and ritual are techniques of: (a) The Milan group (b) The Milwaukee group (c) The Philadelphia group (d) The Galveston group
5. Differentiation of self, triangles and multigenerational transmission belong to: (a) Satir (b) Whitaker (c) Bowen (d) de Shazer
6. Second-order cybernetics holds that: (a) Systems have two levels (b) The observer is part of the observed system (c) Feedback operates twice (d) Two therapists should work together
7. The reflecting team was developed by: (a) Andersen (b) Anderson and Goolishian (c) Seikkula (d) Cecchin
8. Which is the strongest evidence-supported couple therapy? (a) Milan systemic (b) Emotionally focused therapy (c) Strategic therapy (d) Collaborative therapy

Answers. 1 b · 2 c · 3 b · 4 a · 5 c · 6 b · 7 a · 8 b.

Short answers.

What did wave 3 add that wave 1 lacked, and what did it lose? A strong answer names meaning, hypothesis, circular questioning and the reflecting team; then names the loss — therapeutic ambition, responsibility for change, and attention to power and risk.

Why is "integrative" a description of a problem rather than a solution? A strong answer distinguishes integration by theory, technique, sequence and feedback, and shows that each requires a criterion for choosing; without a criterion, integration is incoherence with good manners.

3.16a What the examiners look for

A note on assessment for this week's material, since the examination question on history is one of the most predictable and the most frequently answered badly.

Three habits earn marks. Precision about dates and decades (not "in the seventies" when you mean 1978); attribution that is correct (positive connotation is Milan, not Minuchin); and evaluation — what each wave gained and lost, stated in the same paragraph as the description.

Three habits lose them. The list, in which each model is described in a sentence and nothing is compared; the hagiography, in which founders are praised rather than understood; and the anachronism, in which 1950s claims are judged by 2020s standards without noting that the standards themselves are a product of the intervening argument.

A model sentence for evaluation. "Milan's turn to meaning gave the field its most refined interview technique and deprived it, for a decade, of a theory of action; the reflecting team is best understood as an attempt to recover action without abandoning curiosity." A sentence like that demonstrates that you can hold a gain and a loss at once, which is the intellectual skill this course is trying to build.

3.17 Reflective task

Write 300 words on the model you find most attractive and the model you find most repellent. For each, name the reason — and then check the reason against your own family history. Students usually discover that the attractive model is the one that would have helped their family and the repellent one is the one their family was subjected to. That discovery is not a debunking; it is professional formation, and it is the reason supervision exists.

3.18 Readings for this week

- **Nichols & Schwartz**, Family Therapy: Concepts and Methods, chapters 1–4. The best overview; read it as a map, not as a verdict.
- **Hoffman (1981)**, Foundations of Family Therapy. The history written by someone who was there.
- **Minuchin (1974)**, Families and Family Therapy, chapters 1–3. Read for the clarity of the clinical reasoning, not for the model.
- **Bowen (1978)**, Family Therapy in Clinical Practice, chapters 1–5. Dense, idiosyncratic, foundational.
- **White & Epston (1990)**, Narrative Means to Therapeutic Ends, chapters 1–2. Externalisation, in the original.
- **de Shazer (1985)**, Keys to Solution in Brief Therapy. The miracle question and its rationale.
- **Hare-Mustin (1978)** and **Goldner (1985)**, as for Week 2. The critiques that changed the canon.

Next: Week 4 — Systems concepts you will actually use

3.16b Two worked formulations, same family, different waves

The clearest test of historical knowledge is the ability to formulate the same family in two vocabularies without mixing them. Here are two, both about the Adeyemis, both defensible, written to be read side by side.

Structural formulation. The household is organised around a weak parental subsystem. The father is peripherally involved: he is present, but he occupies a visiting position, offering opinions from outside the executive of the family. The mother–daughter boundary is diffuse; Amara functions as her mother's emotional companion and, in the mornings, as the person who absorbs and then repairs her mother's distress. A stable cross-generational coalition has formed. The school refusal is not a symptom that arrived from nowhere; it is the behaviour that keeps the coalition intact by keeping Amara at home. Target of change: strengthen the parental subsystem, move Amara out of the executive position, and re-establish the sibling subsystem so that the younger brother is not recruited into the space Amara vacates. First move: a joint parental task, attempted in the session, on a real decision.

Bowenian formulation. The family's level of differentiation is low in the marital dyad, and the anxiety that this generates has been triangulated through Amara, who is the child most attuned to her mother and therefore the most available for the family projection process. The father's emotional cutoff from his own family of origin — he has not spoken to his brother in nine years, and his father drank — has left him with no vocabulary for the shame of redundancy and no relationship in which to think about it. The mother's over-functioning is a repetition of her position in her family of origin, where she managed her own mother's depression. Target of change: increase differentiation — the capacity of each adult to stay connected while thinking for themselves — and reduce the triangulation of Amara. First move: a three-generation genogram, followed by coaching the mother to define a position to her own mother, and the father to re-open contact with his brother.

What to notice in comparing them. Structural language gives you an immediate, testable, in-session action; Bowenian language gives you a timeline and a theory of why these particular people, and it produces change slowly, through the adults' own development. Neither is a description of the family; both are descriptions of what the clinician has decided to notice. The mark of a trained clinician is that the choice between them is explicit and defensible rather than temperamental.

> **TASK**
> Write a third formulation, 300 words, in the vocabulary of narrative therapy. Then write one sentence stating what your narrative formulation can see that neither of the above can, and one sentence stating what it cannot see.

Week 4 — Systems concepts you will actually use

Six concepts do most of the clinical work. Learn them precisely; vagueness here produces vague therapy.

1. System and subsystem. A system is a set of elements in interaction such that a change in one produces a change in the others. Subsystems (the couple, the siblings, the parental dyad) are organised by boundaries.

2. Boundary. The invisible rules about who participates and how. Boundaries range from diffuse (enmeshed: little privacy, feelings shared before they are owned) to rigid (disengaged: autonomy without belonging). Healthy is not the middle of a line; healthy is appropriate to the task — the parental subsystem needs a clearer boundary than the sibling subsystem (Figure 5 in MFT 702).

3. Feedback. Negative feedback corrects deviation (a thermostat, a bedtime routine); positive feedback amplifies it (an escalation, a panic spiral). Families contain both, always. Symptoms often persist because a negative-feedback loop protects a positive-feedback loop underneath.

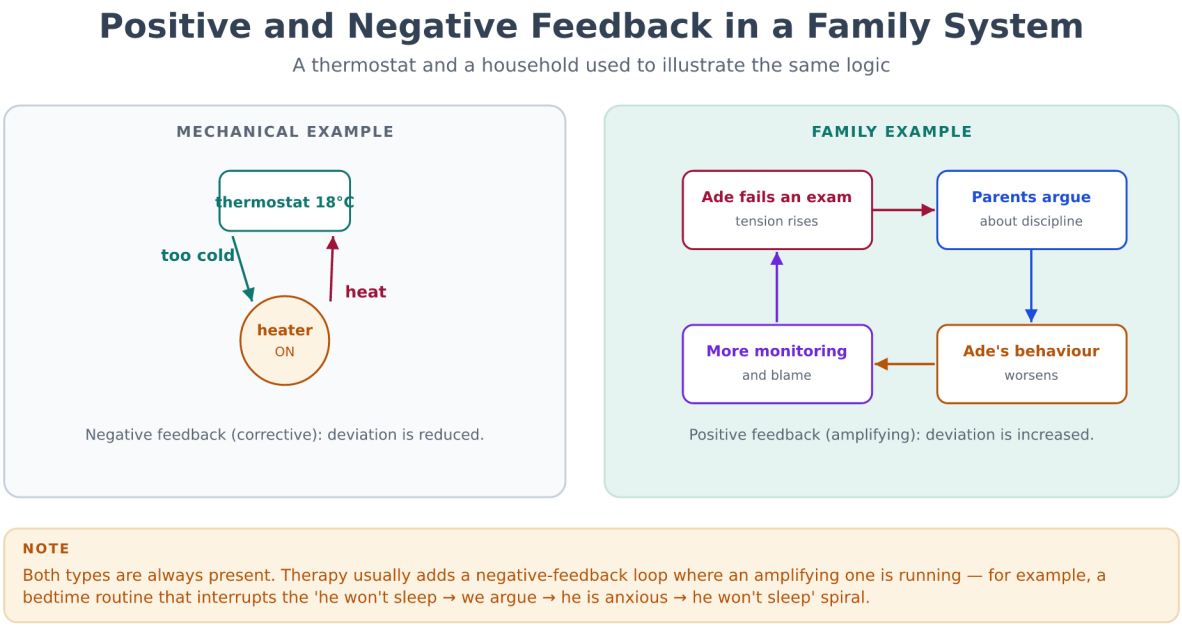


Figure 4.1 — The same feedback logic in a thermostat and in a family

4. Homeostasis. The system's tendency to maintain its familiar organisation, including familiar pathology. This is why a family may resist improvement: the drinking, the fighting, or the symptom has become load-bearing.

5. Rules. Recurrent patterns that prescribe and proscribe behaviour ("we do not discuss money"; "no one is allowed to be angry at Father"). Most family rules are never spoken; they are inferred from what produces anxiety.

6. Triangles. When tension between two people exceeds what the dyad can hold, a third is recruited — a child, an affair, a job, an in-law, a symptom. Triangles distribute anxiety; they also freeze the dyad's capacity to resolve it (covered fully in MFT 715).

> **CASE**
> Since the father's redundancy, the household has run a nightly cycle: he criticises the children's homework, the mother defends them, he accuses her of undermining him, she goes to bed early, and the eldest daughter stays up to calm him. Mapping it: the father's shame (unspoken) → criticism → mother's protection → his isolation → daughter's role as regulator. Nothing here is "the problem". The system has found a way to hold his shame — at the cost of a 14-year-old's adolescence.

Practice (lab). Using the case above, label each element: boundary, feedback type, homeostatic function, rule, triangle. Then answer: what would have to change elsewhere if the daughter stopped regulating?

Week 5 — The profession: identity, scope and settings

Family therapy is a distinct profession with its own training standards, codes and legal standing, and it is also a transdisciplinary competence. You need both facts.

Scope of practice. Assessing and treating relational distress; couple and marital therapy; family therapy with children and adolescents; parent guidance; separation and divorce work; work with stepfamilies; group work with relational focus; consultation to organisations. In most jurisdictions, family therapists do **not** prescribe medication, conduct forensic custody evaluations of their own clients, or give legal advice.

Settings. Private practice, community mental health, hospitals (including paediatric and psychiatric liaison), schools, child protection services, addiction services, employee assistance programmes, faith-based counselling centres, NGOs in humanitarian settings, and court-connected mediation.

Teamwork. You will work alongside psychiatrists, paediatricians, social workers, teachers, probation officers, imams and pastors, and community health workers. Two skills matter more than you expect: writing a referral that says what you want, and knowing the boundaries of what you may disclose.

Professional identity. Three tensions recur in the literature and in practice:

1. **Expert or collaborator?** The field has moved from therapist-as-director to therapist-as-curious- participant, but families often want expertise. The mature position is "expert in process, not in their lives".
2. **Neutral or advocating?** Systemic neutrality does not require moral neutrality about violence.
3. **Specialist or generalist?** You will be asked to work with issues you were not trained for. The professional answer is competence boundaries plus referral, not improvisation.

> **CASE**
> A school refers a 12-year-old for "aggression". The school wants an assessment letter; the mother wants the school to stop the bullying; the father does not want to attend. Assume nothing. Ask who defined the problem, who benefits from that definition, and what the referral is for. Then write down your scope: what you will assess, what you will not, and to whom you will send what.

> **PRACTICAL**
> Draft a one-page "Scope of practice" statement for yourself as an intern. Include the three things you will not do without supervision.

Week 6 — The first session I: joining

The idea. Joining is the process of becoming part of the system sufficiently to influence it, without becoming so much a part of it that you lose the capacity to observe. Minuchin called it the therapist's "accommodation" to the family's style. It is not friendliness; it is deliberate.

Four joining moves:

1. **Track the family's language.** Use their words, not your diagnostic ones. If they say "he is stubborn", ask about "stubborn" before you ask about "oppositionality".
2. **Validate what is true in each person's account.** Not "you are right", but "that makes sense given what you have been carrying".
3. **Match pace and formality.** Some families want a structured interview; others need ten minutes of narrative before any structure is tolerable. Ask: "How would you like to use this hour?"
4. **Make the structure explicit.** Who is here, why, for how long, who knows, what is confidential. Anxiety drops when the frame is clear.

What to cover in a first session (the "minimum viable first session"):

Element	Sample wording
Contract and limits	"I will keep what is said here private, except where someone is at risk of harm."
Each person's view	"I would like to hear from each of you — what worries you most?"
The attempted solutions	"What have you already tried? What happened?"
The pattern	"So when X happens, what does Y do? And then?"
Risk screen	"Is anyone being hurt at home? Any thoughts of ending your life?"
Feedback	"Here is what I think I heard. What have I got wrong?"
Next step	"I would like to see all of you again next week, including your father."

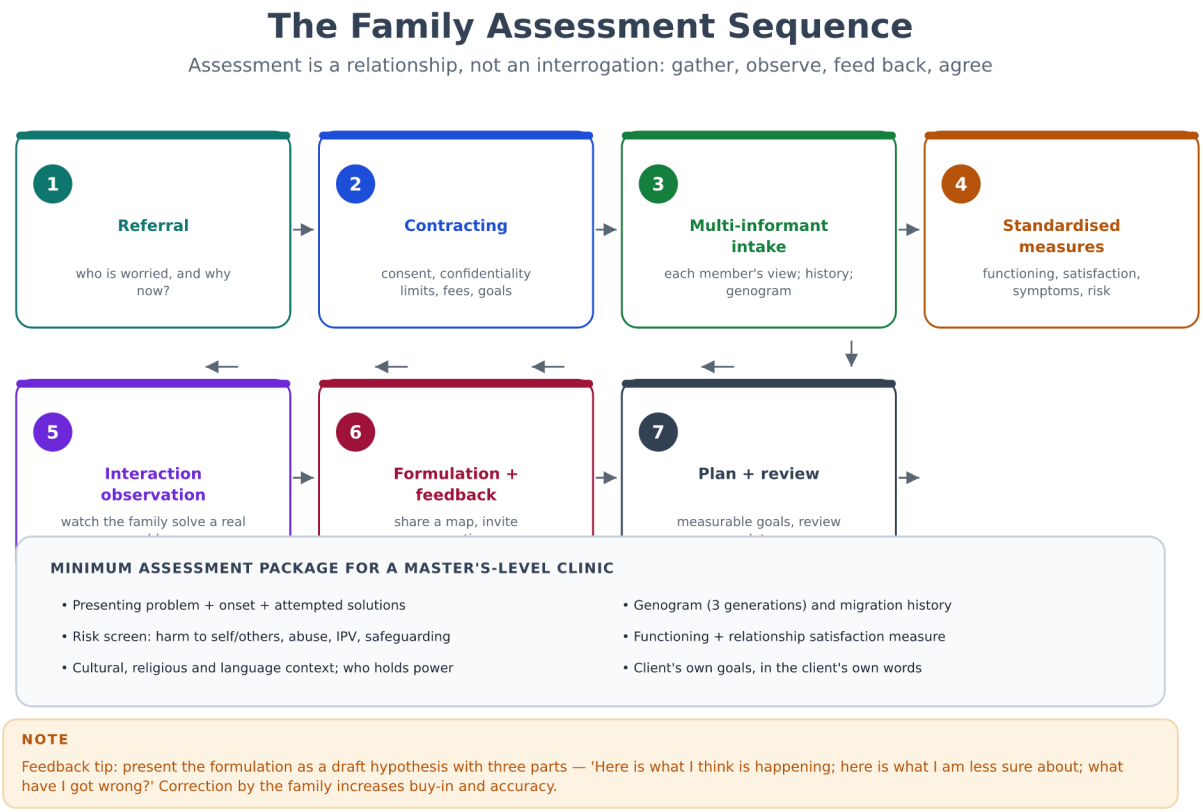


Figure 6.1 — The assessment sequence: assessment is a relationship, not an interrogation

CASE

A family arrives furious with each other and with the referrer. The therapist's first sentence is not a question but an acknowledgment: "You have been sent here by three different people and none of them asked you what you wanted. Let's start there." Joining succeeded before any information was gathered.

PRACTICAL (SKILLS GATE)

Fifteen minutes, observed. You must (1) state confidentiality and its limits, (2) obtain a description of the problem from at least two people, (3) ask one circular question, (4) complete a risk screen, (5) offer a summary and invite correction. You may use one index card of prompts. Feedback uses the four-point structured sheet in the programme handbook.

Week 7 — The first session II: defining the problem

The referral question is rarely the clinical question. Your task is to negotiate a problem definition that is (a) specific, (b) interactional, (c) owned by the family, and (d) changeable.

From vague to specific. "He is disrespectful" → "When I ask him to help, he looks at his phone and says nothing. That happens most evenings, and then I shout."

From individual to interactional. "She is manipulative" → "When she cries, her father gives in and you feel undermined; then you withdraw, and she comes to me." Notice: no blame is removed, but the description now includes three people and a sequence.

From imposed to owned. Ask each person to complete: "I will know this has worked when…". Write the answers down and read them back. If the parents' answers are incompatible, that incompatibility is the work.

From unchangeable to changeable. "I want him to respect me" is a relational outcome that no one can deliver on demand. "I want us to agree on one consequence for phone use, and both apply it for a week" is testable.

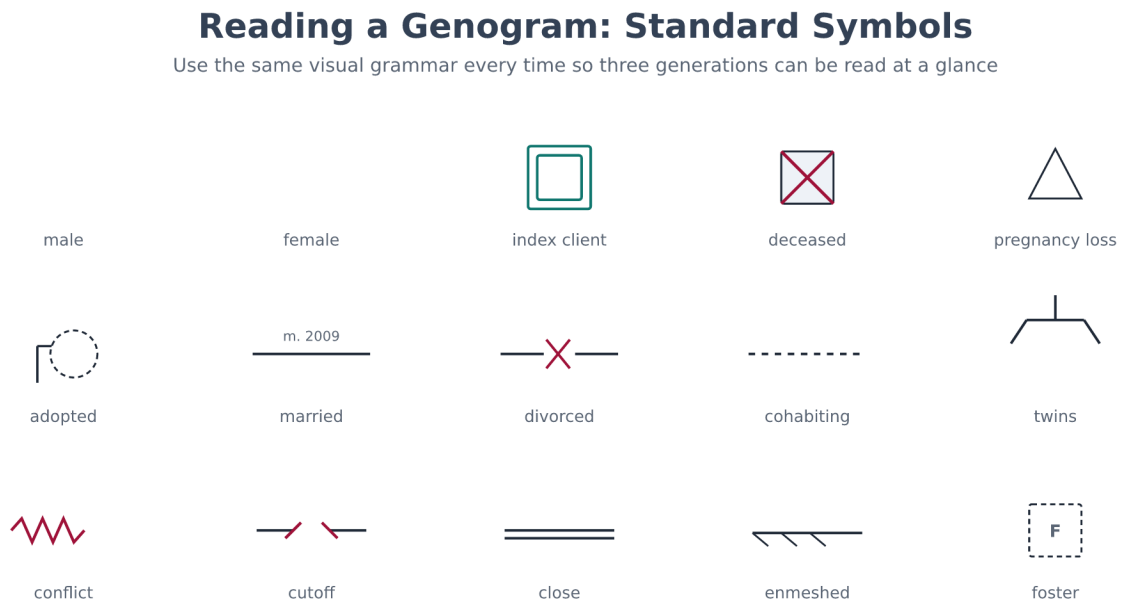
> **CASE**
> The Adeyemis come because their 16-year-old, Amara, has refused school for six weeks. The referral says "school refusal". The negotiated definition becomes: "The mornings have become a battle that everyone loses; Amara does not leave the house; her mother stays home from work; her father works later; and her brother has started sleeping in her room." The problem is now a system, not a girl.

Practice (lab). Take a complaint a peer brings from placement (disguised) and rewrite it four times: specific, interactional, owned, changeable. Read the final version to the "family" and ask whether it is recognisable.

Week 8 — The genogram as a hypothesis machine

The genogram is a three-generation map of family structure, relationships and events. Drawing it is simple; using it is not — the value lies in the hypotheses it generates and the questions it permits.

Standard symbols (Figure 3) and conventions: squares for males, circles for females, horizontal line for marriage, slash for divorce, cross for death, double outline for the index client. Relationship lines: double for close, zigzag for conflict, broken with slashes for cutoff, triple for enmeshed.



NOTE

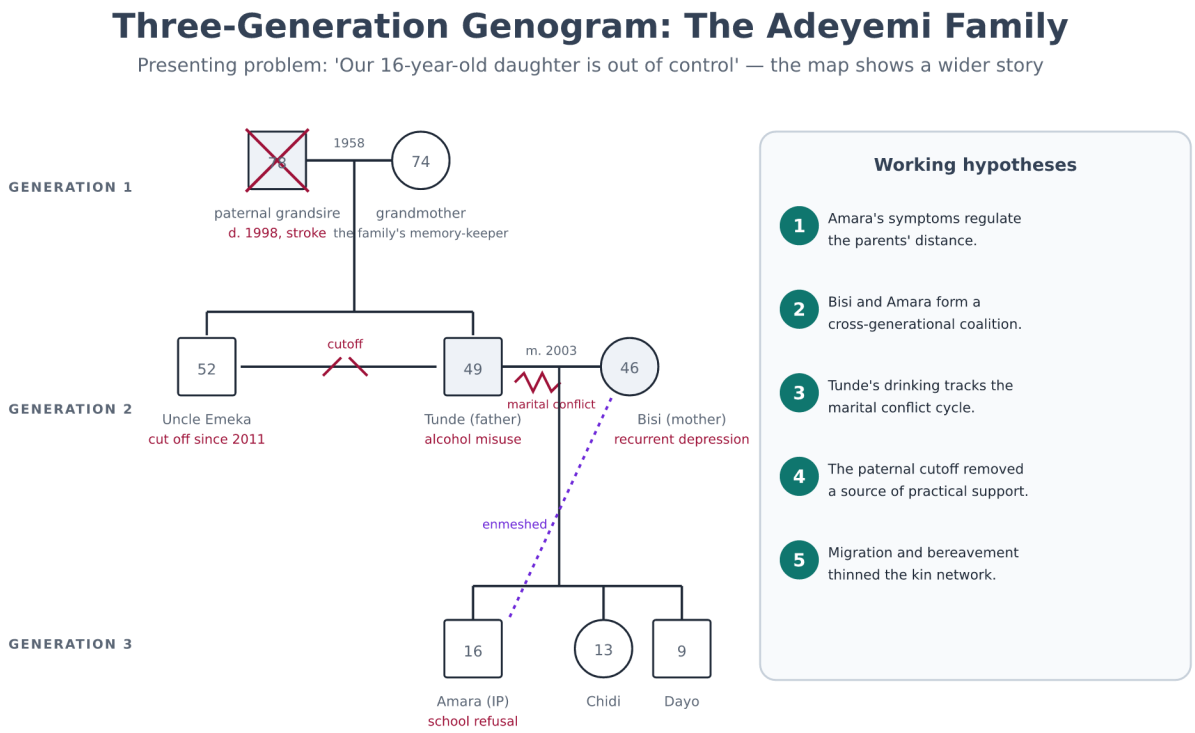
Also record: ages or year of birth inside the symbol, date and cause of death above it, occupation, migration, religion, and significant secrets (affairs, incarceration, abuse) using a key that you explain to the family before you draw.

Figure 3 — Genogram symbols: learn the grammar once and three generations become readable

What to ask while drawing. Age and year of birth; occupation and migration; deaths and their causes; separations, divorces, remarriages; who is close to whom; who does not speak to whom; who is the "responsible one"; who "had a breakdown"; family secrets; repeating names; repeating ages at which things happened.

From map to hypothesis. A good genogram yields three kinds of hypothesis:

1. **Structural** — coalitions, cutoffs, over/under-functioning pairs.
2. **Temporal** — patterns repeating at the same age, or symptom onset clustering around anniversaries.
3. **Legacy** — loyalty, indebtedness, roles inherited ("the eldest daughter always cares for everyone").



NOTE

Notice what the map does NOT tell you: the meaning the family gives to father's drinking, the voice of the absent uncle, and the resources (church, neighbours, income) that are not drawn. A genogram is a hypothesis generator, not a verdict.

Figure 8.1 — A worked three-generation genogram with hypotheses

Cultural note. In many families the genogram must include people who are not biologically related but are structurally central — a foster child, a co-wife, a pastor, a long-term house help. Ask, "who else belongs to this family?" before you decide the map is complete.

PRACTICAL

Draw your own three-generation genogram from memory first, then correct it with a relative. Note every place where your memory and theirs differ. Those differences are the assignment.

Week 9 — Formulating relationally

A formulation is a provisional, testable explanation that connects the presenting problem to the system that maintains it, and points to where you would intervene.

Use the 5-P grid (presenting, predisposing, precipitating, perpetuating, protective) and add two relational columns: who is involved and what function the symptom serves.

Domain	Adeyemi family
Presenting	Amara, 16, school refusal × 6 weeks; parental conflict over discipline
Predisposing	Maternal depression; paternal alcohol misuse; migration severed the extended-family buffer
Precipitating	Father's redundancy; best friend left the city; transition to senior secondary
Perpetuating	Pursue–withdraw cycle between parents; mother–daughter coalition; avoidance rewarded by anxiety relief; disrupted sleep
Protective	Both parents attend; church community; Amara's engagement with art; an aunt who is trusted

The intervention sentence. End every formulation with one sentence of the form: "Given X, Y and Z, the most useful focus now is W, because it is the most changeable and the most load-bearing." For the Adeyemis: "Given the coalition and the parental distance, the most useful focus now is the couple's conflict cycle, because it is what the symptom is currently regulating."

Share it. A formulation that is never spoken is a private theory. Offer it as a draft with three parts: here is what I think, here is what I am unsure about, here is what I need from you.

> **ASSIGNMENT (30%)**
> 2,000 words plus a genogram. Choose a disguised or composite family from placement or a detailed role-play. Include: genogram, 5-P grid, circular formulation with a diagram, three competing hypotheses, one intervention plan with rationale, and a reflection on your own reactivity to this family.

Week 10 — Culture, class and power

Every family you meet is embedded in a culture, and so are you. Culture is not a variable to be "controlled for"; it is the medium in which the problem is defined.

Four practical disciplines.

1. **Ask rather than assume.** "In your family, who usually makes the big decisions? Who is consulted? Is that how you want it to be?"
2. **Locate yourself.** Complete the same cultural genogram for your own family. Your views on hierarchy, individuation, duty and disclosure are not neutral.
3. **Notice the power in the room** — including yours. The family may be polite because of your status, not because they agree.
4. **Interrogate "normal".** Models that prize individuation can pathologise families who prize interdependence. Ask what the family's own picture of a good life is.

Language. If the family thinks in their first language about emotional matters, the session may need that language or an interpreter. Interpreters are not furniture: brief

them, seat them beside you, ask them to interpret speech not summaries, and never ask them to translate a disclosure you have not prepared for.

Religion and spirituality. In much of the world, faith is not an "aspect" of family life; it is the organising frame. Ask what the family's faith says about the problem, who in the religious community knows, and whether they want that person involved. Do not compete with the pastor or imam; coordinate.

> **CASE**
> A couple is referred after the wife disclosed to her pastor that her husband has been violent twice. She does not want the police involved and does not want her family told. The therapist must hold three things at once: respect for her autonomy and faith, a safety plan that does not depend on him changing, and honesty about the limits of confidentiality. (Full treatment in MFT 712 and 724.)

> **REFLECT**
> Where in your own family would a therapist from a different culture misread the structure? Write 300 words on what they would get wrong and why.

Week 11 — What the evidence says

Students often arrive believing either that therapy "just works" or that only manualised treatments do. The evidence is more interesting than either position.

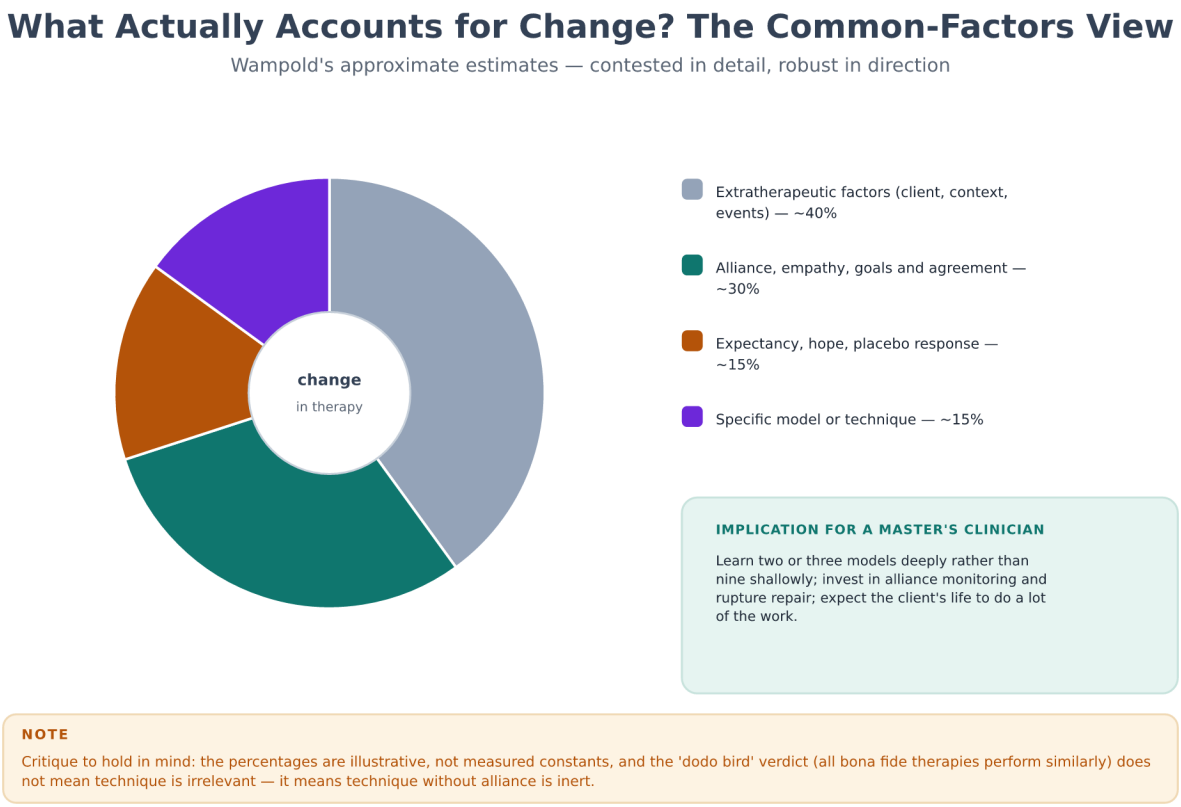


Figure 11.1 — Common factors and model effects, with a critique

Four findings worth carrying into practice.

1. **Family and couple therapies work.** Meta-analyses consistently find moderate-to-large effects for couple therapy in relationship distress, and for family-based treatments in adolescent behaviour problems, eating disorders (family-based treatment for anorexia is a first-line intervention), substance misuse and psychosis relapse.
2. **Alliance matters, and it is relational.** In couple and family work, the alliance is not one relationship but several, and shared sense of purpose predicts outcome better than any single dyad's alliance with the therapist.
3. **Model differences are smaller than model loyalties suggest.** Common-factors research attributes much of the variance to client factors, alliance and expectancy. Technique is not irrelevant: it organises what the therapist notices and does, and it matters more for specific problems.
4. **Drop-out is the silent failure.** In couple and family work, 20–40% of families end therapy unilaterally. Attendance, engagement and early change are the best predictors of retention. Track them.

How to read a paper in ten minutes. Read the abstract; then the design (who, how many, compared to what); then the outcome measure (does it measure what you care about?); then the effect size, not the p-value; then the limitations; then ask whether the sample resembles your clinic.

> **CRITICAL READING**
> Choose one randomised trial of a family therapy model and one qualitative study of family therapy experience. Write 500 words comparing what each can and cannot tell you.

Week 12 — Ethics, risk and the limits of the systemic frame

Ethics is not a chapter at the end of the course; it is the frame that makes the work possible. Here we establish the four issues every family therapist meets in the first month.

1. Confidentiality in a multiperson system. There is no single confidentiality. Agree the rules at the start: what is said in the joint session is shared; what is told to you individually may need to be brought into the open; secrets that affect safety cannot be kept. Write the policy down and give it to the family.

2. Risk. Screen for suicide, self-harm, violence, abuse and neglect in every new case, and document it. You cannot assume a colleague has done it.

3. Competence. Taking a case you are not trained for is not courage. It is a risk to the client and to you.

4. Multiple relationships and power. Small communities, religious networks and family ties make dual relationships likely. The test is not "is there a second relationship?" but "does the second relationship impair the first, or exploit the first?"

> **CASE**
> During an individual session, a husband tells you he has resumed an affair and asks you not to tell his wife. He is not at risk and no one is being harmed in the sense that requires disclosure. What do you do? (Work this case in groups; then compare with the decision model in Figure 33, MFT 704.)

Documentation. Write notes as if a colleague will take over tomorrow and a court may read them in a year: date, attendees, presenting issues, risk screen result, interventions, plan, and who was told what.

Week 13 — Integration I: three lenses on one family

This week is a rehearsal for MFT 702. You will apply three models to the same case and notice that each produces a different question, a different focus and a different first move.

Model	Key question	First move with the Adeyemis	Likely risk
Structural	What is the hierarchy, and where are the boundaries?	Strengthen the parental subsystem; block the mother–daughter coalition	Imposing a structure the family experiences as foreign

Model	Key question	First move with the Adeyemis	Likely risk
Bowen/multigenerational	How does anxiety travel, and who absorbs it?	Coach the parents to manage their own reactivity; map the projection onto Amara	Slow; family may want symptom relief now
Solution-focused	What is already working, and what would "one point better" look like?	Find exceptions to school refusal; scale the parents' confidence	May bypass the function of the symptom

The point of the exercise is not to choose a winner. It is to notice that a family presents a plural reality and that your model determines what you can see. Good clinicians can move between at least two frames without losing coherence.

> **PRACTICAL**
> In groups, take the same case and produce three one-page plans. Present all three. Then answer: which would you start with, and what would make you change your mind?

Week 14 — Integration II: your emerging clinical stance

Write a two-page **position statement**: what you believe about how relational problems develop, what you think therapy does, what you will not do, and what you still do not know. This is not an exam answer; it is the beginning of a professional identity that will be revised for the rest of your career.

A strong statement includes: one theoretical commitment, one epistemological commitment (how you know what you know), one ethical commitment, one cultural commitment, and one honest limitation.

> **REFLECT**
> Read your Week 1 reflection again. What has changed? What has not? Write 300 words to yourself, dated, to be reread at the end of the programme.

Integration: the whole course on two pages

1. The frame. Treat the relationship as the client. Widen the field; include context; notice the observer.

2. Causality. Move from who-started-it to what-maintains-it. Draw the loop. Punctuate differently.

3. History. Five movements: pre-history, research rupture, heroic era, critique and meaning, evidence and integration. Each school answers a limitation of its predecessor.

4. Concepts. System, subsystem, boundary, feedback, homeostasis, rule, triangle. Six concepts, most of the clinical work.

5. Profession. Know your scope, your setting, your team, your limits. Refer well.

6. The first session. Join, contract, hear everyone, screen for risk, map the pattern, summarise, invite correction, agree next step.

7. The problem definition. Specific, interactional, owned, changeable.

8. The genogram. Three generations, structural and temporal hypotheses, cultural completeness.

9. Formulation. 5-P plus "who is involved" and "what function the symptom serves", ending with one intervention sentence.

10. Culture and power. Ask, locate yourself, notice power, interrogate normal.

11. Evidence. Family therapy works; alliance matters; models overlap; drop-out is the silent failure.

12. Ethics. Confidentiality is negotiated, risk is screened, competence is bounded, dual roles are examined, notes are written for strangers.

13. Integration. Multiple lenses; move between frames without losing coherence.

14. Stance. A written, revisable position on what you believe and what you do not know.

Glossary

Boundary — the implicit rules governing participation and closeness between subsystems. **Circular causality** — an account in which each element both causes and is caused by the others. **Coalition** — an alliance of two or more people against a third. **Cybernetics** — the study of control and communication in systems; first-order (observer outside), second-order (observer inside). **Detriangulation** — the process of extricating a third party from a dyadic conflict. **Enmeshment** — diffuse boundaries with excessive emotional sharing and low autonomy. **Disengagement** — rigid boundaries with little emotional contact. **Feedback (negative)** — a process that reduces deviation and restores stability. **Feedback (positive)** — a process that amplifies deviation and produces escalation. **Genogram** — a three-generation diagram of family structure, relationships and events. **Homeostasis** — the system's tendency to maintain its existing organisation. **Hypothesis** — a provisional, testable explanation that guides enquiry. **Joining** — the therapist's deliberate accommodation to a family's style in order to work with it. **Linear causality** — an account in which A causes B in one direction. **Punctuation** — the way each participant marks the beginning of a sequence, thereby assigning blame. **Reframe** — relabelling a behaviour so that it is understood in a new, usually relational, frame. **Subsystem** — a unit within a system organised by boundaries (couple, siblings, parental dyad). **System** — a set of interacting elements such that a change in one changes the others. **Triangle** — a three-person configuration that absorbs and stabilises dyadic tension.

Self-assessment

Multiple choice (answers below)

1. A therapist says, "The real question is not who started the argument but what keeps it going." This statement reflects: (a) linear causality (b) circular causality (c) psychodynamic causality (d) moral causality

2. A father's drinking has the effect of preventing his wife and son from discussing the son's expulsion. In systemic terms the drinking is: (a) random (b) homeostatic (c) an individual symptom only (d) irrelevant to the family

3. "We never discuss money" is best described as: (a) a boundary (b) a family rule (c) a triangle (d) a reframe

4. In second-order cybernetics the therapist is: (a) outside the system (b) part of the observed system (c) a neutral observer (d) irrelevant

5. The best first move with a family that arrives furious at the referrer is: (a) correct the misunderstanding immediately (b) acknowledge their experience of being sent (c) begin the assessment (d) ask who is the identified patient

6. A negotiated problem definition should be specific, interactional, owned and: (a) clinically imposed (b) changeable (c) blame-allocating (d) historical

7. Which is not an element of a minimum first session? (a) confidentiality and limits (b) a risk screen (c) a full genogram (d) a summary and invitation to correct

8. The strongest predictor of drop-out in couple and family work is: (a) diagnosis (b) therapist's model (c) early engagement and early change (d) family size

9. "Multigenerational transmission" belongs to which tradition? (a) structural (b) Bowen (c) Milan (d) solution-focused

10. The statement "expert in process, not in their lives" describes: (a) neutrality about violence (b) the therapist's stance (c) a legal requirement (d) a diagnostic rule

Answer key

1 b · 2 b · 3 b · 4 b · 5 b · 6 b · 7 c · 8 c · 9 b · 10 b

Short answer (150 words each)

1. Explain the difference between negative and positive feedback using a family example.
2. Why is "punctuation" clinically useful? Give a sample question.
3. Name three limits of confidentiality in family work and how you would state each to a family.
4. What is the difference between a genogram and a formulation?
5. Summarise the common-factors critique of model loyalty in four sentences.

Essay questions (choose one, 1,500 words)

1. "Family therapy is a frame, not a technique." Discuss with reference to at least two models and one case from your placement.
2. Critically evaluate the claim that systemic neutrality is impossible — and undesirable — in cases of domestic violence.
3. Using a disguised case, demonstrate how a linear formulation and a circular formulation would lead to different treatment plans. Which would you choose and why?

Practical and clinical log requirements

For each session you observe or conduct, record:

Field	Requirement
Date and duration	Exact
Attendees	Relationship to index client; ages; who was absent
Referral source and question	In the referrer's words
Presenting problem	In each attendee's words
Risk screen	Completed Y/N; result; action
Pattern observed	One loop or sequence, described behaviourally
Intervention	What you did, and why
Response	What happened next
Supervision	Who, when, what was discussed
Plan	Next step, with review date

The log is assessed for **specificity and consistency**, not for how impressive the case was. A log of ordinary sessions written precisely will score higher than a dramatic case written vaguely.

Further reading

Core texts

- Nichols, M. P., & Davis, S. (2021). Family Therapy: Concepts and Methods (12th ed.). Pearson.
- Becvar, D. S., & Becvar, R. J. (2018). Family Therapy: A Systemic Integration (9th ed.). Pearson.
- Dallos, R., & Draper, R. (2015). An Introduction to Family Therapy (4th ed.). Open University Press.

Foundations and history

- Watzlawick, P., Beavin, J., & Jackson, D. (1967). Pragmatics of Human Communication. Norton.
- Bateson, G. (1972). Steps to an Ecology of Mind. Chandler.
- Hoffman, L. (1981). Foundations of Family Therapy. Basic Books.
- Gurman, A. S., Lebow, J. L., & Snyder, D. K. (Eds.). (2015). Clinical Handbook of Couple Therapy (5th ed.). Guilford.

Practice and technique

- Minuchin, S., & Fishman, H. C. (1981). Family Therapy Techniques. Harvard University Press.
- Haley, J. (1980). Leaving Home. McGraw-Hill.
- McGoldrick, M., Gerson, R., & Petry, S. (2020). Genograms: Assessment and Treatment (4th ed.). Norton.

Culture and critique

- McGoldrick, M., Giordano, J., & Garcia-Preto, N. (Eds.). (2005). Ethnicity and Family Therapy (3rd ed.). Guilford.
- Hare-Mustin, R. (1978). A feminist approach to family therapy. Family Process, 17(2), 181–194.

Evidence

- Wampold, B. E., & Imel, Z. E. (2015). The Great Psychotherapy Debate (2nd ed.). Routledge.
- Sprenkle, D. H., Davis, S. D., & Lebow, J. L. (2009). Common Factors in Couple and Family Therapy. Guilford.
- Shadish, W. R., & Baldwin, S. A. (2003). Effects of family and marital psychotherapies: A meta-analysis. Journal of Consulting and Clinical Psychology, 71(6), 1080–1097.

Codes and standards

- American Association for Marriage and Family Therapy. (2015). Code of Ethics.
- International Association of Marriage and Family Counselors. Ethical Code.

Next: MFT 702 — Theories of Family Therapy